

W O U N D

TEMPORAL ECHOES / EMIT



WOUND · TEMPORAL ECHOES · EMIT

A Solo Journaling RPG
Duology About Memory,
Loss,
and What We Become

FIRST EDITION · 2026

A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

You're reading something that came to me at the lowest point in my life.

I had just gotten out of the hospital with my kid, a beautiful eight-month-old boy who worked harder than anyone I've ever met at the things most of us take for granted — eating and breathing. We went to the hospital after seven months of constant screaming, endless vomiting, and only gaining one pound. If you aren't a parent, take my word: it was bad.

During the first seven months after my wife had given birth, we were in a constant struggle for survival. Visiting specialists whose titles I couldn't pronounce, never sleeping more than an hour at a time because every time he wakes up is an opportunity to get some more calories in. Fighting with feeding trackers and hollowing ourselves out, day by day, while we wondered what was wrong with our kid and why no one had an answer.

Getting to the hospital was a relief, in a way. It meant the cavalry had arrived and we could — well, not relax, but finally let an adult figure out what was going on. Turns out, our kid had an ultra-rare lung disease. Only about a

Of course, that didn't count for much when I arrived back in the office. After a week back, my boss and the manager called me in for a meeting on a half hour's notice. They didn't tell me what it was about. They slid some papers across the table at me. Performance Improvement Plan. 'We want this to work, but your numbers were just too low these past few months. But we like you. The problem is that you're just too damn likable.' They slapped me on the back and said I was a good man. I was numb, but I'd been through tougher straits before. I'd buckle down and beat the PIP. After all, what is getting told that you're not good enough compared to watching your child fight for his life?

But then, the kicker came.

I lost my tefillin. If you know you know. Between my kid's health issues, the pressures of my job, and my newfound inability to connect with God in the way I'd done for over two decades, I finally crumpled. I sat down in my office's wellness room — reserved for nursing mothers, but I didn't care — and cried like my baby couldn't.

I saw these two manuscripts in the corner of the room, tied together with a bit of twine. Stains streaked the pages — I couldn't tell if it was ink, blood or something else.

Screw it.

If you're reading this, it means you found this copy. If you're holding it in your hands — be careful what you write in the margins. The book remembers.

I didn't know then that the two voices arguing in those pages had once been something like friends. Something like allies. They shared a moment I've only glimpsed in fragments — a night in 1944, a burning building, a choice that broke four people into the four philosophies that now hunt each other across the timestream.

Temporal Echoes is Dr. Eleanor Chen's preservation manual. She believes you can come home intact. She's spent thirty years documenting how to survive displacement without losing yourself.

emiT is Alan Rose's transformation protocol. He believes trying to preserve your original identity is expensive, painful, and ultimately futile. His book is about becoming operationally effective through change — about finding out what you're capable of when you stop spending everything you have on staying the same.

Both books use the same mechanical systems. Both are brutal. Neither wins.

HOW TO USE THIS BOOK

This duology is two complete, playable games. You can read and play either book independently. If you play both with the same Echo — first Chen's path, then Alan's — something additional opens up: a conversation between the two books about what preservation costs and what transformation takes. The rules for carrying a character between them are in the section called Playing Both.

Temporal Echoes is designed for progressive complexity. Do not read it cover to cover. You will be overwhelmed and you will quit. Read in stages.

YOUR FIRST 3 OR 4 SESSIONS — READ ONLY THIS

Chapters 1–5 (Chapters 1–5 of Temporal Echoes) The Action Oracle (Appendix C.3) This is all you need to survive your first jumps. You will not understand the rest yet. That is intentional.

WHEN CRISIS HITS (**PARADOX** 7+ OR **COHERENCE** -6) — ADD THIS

Chapter 6: Crisis Management Chapter 7: Advanced Systems Faction Profiles (Appendix D) The universe has noticed you. Now you need the rules of engagement.

ENDGAME & DEEP REFERENCE — UNLOCK WHEN READY

The Harmonic Codex (Appendix A) — the physics behind everything Full Oracle Tables (Appendix C.1 & C.2) Captivity Vignettes (Appendix E) Chapter 8: Long-Term Play Start simple. The complexity will find you.

YOUR FIRST SESSION — A GUIDED START

Don't read the whole book. Do this instead:

1. Read the Foreword — 'A Note Before You Begin.' Feel the vibe.
2. Create your Echo (Chapter 2). Follow the steps. Use pencil. Spend no more than 30 minutes. Perfect is the enemy of started.
3. Read 'Opening the Session' (Chapter 3). Answer the question: What is my Echo trying to find out right now?
4. Roll on the Anomaly Tables (Appendix C.1). This is where you land. Don't try to Navigate yet.
5. Write in your Chronicle. What do you see? Who is here? What feels wrong?
6. Want something? Roll for it. **2d6** + your best Mode. If a Memory fits, add +2.
7. End the scene. Write what changed.

That's it. You've played your first session. The Factions, the Crises, the full Navigation system — they'll find you

DOCUMENT STRUCTURE

Book 1: Temporal Echoes (Chapters 1-8) Dr. Eleanor Chen's preservation manual.

Book 2: emiT (Chapters 1-6) Alan Rose's transformation protocol.

Appendices: Appendix A: The Harmonic Codex Appendix B: Asset Catalogs Appendix C: Oracle Tables C.1: Anomaly Tables (Temporal Echoes) C.2: The Chronoscape (emiT) C.3: Shared Oracles Appendix D: The Factions Appendix D.1: Recovered Field Intelligence Appendix E: Captivity Vignettes Appendix F: Examples of Play Appendix G: Temporal Pathologies Appendix H: Recovered Testimony — The Saul Files Quick Reference Sheet Character Sheets

TEMPORAL ECHOES

A Solo Journaling RPG About Memory, Loss, and the Fight to Stay Human

By Dr. Eleanor Chen

| *Hoc fit, ergo diligenter lege.*



CHAPTER I

Understanding Displacement



Time is an ocean. I know the river metaphor is older and more familiar, but set it down before we go any further, because the river is what kills new Echoes faster than anything else.

Rivers have banks, direction and flow. You can float in a river. Oceans have waves, predators and unfathomable depth. You can't float in the Chronoverse, and if you think that time will carry you forward, your existence will prove to be both finite and short.

You've been Displaced — torn from normal temporal flow, drifting between historical eras, trying to hold yourself together as you do. What's left of you is called an Echo. As you travel, your memories will fade, erode, and distort. The question isn't whether that happens. It's which pieces go first, and who you are without them.

Temporal Echoes is a mediation on time travel, memory, and identity. It's played alone, with a journal, and it is not gentle.

WHAT IT MEANS TO BE AN ECHO

You can't stay. I've watched Echoes try every version of permanence available to them. Marriages. Children. Foundations. None of it held for more than a generation. The era catches on. Sometimes within a year. Sometimes within forty. But never longer than that.

Your mind is finite; I wrote the mathematics that proved your memory capacity is quantifiable and limited. New experiences push old ones out at a rate that doesn't care how much you loved the old ones. Without active intervention, you'll forget what makes you yourself inside of fifty years. I'm sorry. That's the substrate we're working against.

The timeline treats you as a foreign object. Actions that contradict history generate Paradox. Paradox destabilizes the timeline and you both. The CTH metaphor I usually reach for is a cello playing the wrong note in a string quartet. The metaphor breaks down when you remember the cello is also dissolving while it plays.

In my years of displacement, I've developed a working theory about what we are. We're not travelers — we're dissonant waveforms attempting to maintain coherence within the harmonic field of causality. Every moment in history has a specific resonance, an emotional weight, and a stubborn resistance to change. When we displace, we're forcing our personal waveform to resonate with a target node's frequency.

The math holds under pressure. Coherence is measurable. Echoes are literally waveforms trying not to collapse amidst an ocean of static and competing waves.

You don't need to understand the equations to play. But if you want to know where the road ends, see Appendix A: The Harmonic Codex.

— EC

You're not trying to 'maintain coherence,' kid. You already failed. The moment you displaced, your waveform shattered.

Chen writes like the ocean is something you can negotiate with. I've been in it for 340 years. It doesn't negotiate.

—AR

THREE QUESTIONS

The questions an Echo asks tell me more than their answers do, because they also show what the Echo has already *stopped* asking. An Echo who no longer asks whether they can return has decided something, even if they wouldn't admit it. An Echo who no longer asks whether their identity is worth preserving is preparing for what comes after, which I have learned not to name out loud.

These are the three questions I have never met an Echo who could avoid for long.

Every Echo must eventually answer these:

- Can I return to my origin?
- Should I preserve my original identity?
- What happens if I forget who I was?

She's wrong about the order. The first question every Echo asks is "what year is it." The second is "where am I." She skips both because she had a lab and is into math. Most people have neither.

—AR

This game is the process of living with those questions. It does not guarantee answers.

The Four Factions

Four major Factions have emerged from the Chronoverse, each with their own reasons for hunting you.

The Church believes suffering stabilizes time. They want your pain. The Loop Authority sees recursion as correction. They want you normalized. Scionfall believes cessation is mercy. They will seduce you with kindness. The Tangled Revel shatter Echoes into knotted masterpieces.

Accepting their offers is drinking from a poisoned chalice. Rejecting their help is drowning in a poisoned pool.

I've heard Echoes call the Factions evil. That's a mistake and an understatement. Each Faction has looked at the mathematics of temporal displacement and drawn a different answer to the same question.

The Church is correct that focused belief collapses probability. The Authority is right that recursion normalizes waveforms. Scionfall is fundamentally correct that cessation ends suffering. The Revel are right that instability creates infinite possibility.

I've worked with the Loop Authority dozens of times. They are at least coherent and dependable.

— EC

Think of them as immune responses. The Chronoverse doesn't want you here, and neither do they. You're the infection. And there are way more than four.

—AR

WHAT YOU NEED TO PLAY

Two six-sided dice. Two ten-sided dice. A sturdy pen. You will write more than you expect to. And a journal, which I call your Chronicle throughout this manual.

Chronicling is not optional. It is the only thing standing between your current identity and total dissolution.

Barrier, or tombstone? Depends what year you ask me.

—AR

THE LOOP: HOW A SESSION RUNS

A session follows a rhythm. Learn it so well that it feels like breathing. You should be able to do it without thinking.

1. Play. Navigate through time, encounter situations, make choices. When the outcome is uncertain and the stakes are real, roll **2d6** + Mode + Memory bonus.
2. Resolve. On **10+**, you succeed. On **7-9**, you succeed with a cost or complication. On **6-**, you fail and face consequences.
3. Record. Write what happened in your Chronicle. This is how you preserve yourself.
4. End Session. When you reach a natural stopping point, perform Downtime. This is when Memories fade, Assets repair, and you prepare for the next session.

Hofstadter wrote about strange loops, systems that contain themselves, that reference themselves into being. An Echo is a strange loop, where the Echo's identity is the system that observes the system. When the loop tightens, you become more yourself. When it slackens, you become less. — EC

— EC

An example, from my own field notes.

Cambridge, May of 1842. I was tracking an Echo who had been displaced during the Anomaly cluster of 2031 and had landed inside the run-up to the Great Exhibition. The light there was thicker than any light I have stood in since. Coal smoke held in the air the way fog holds. People walked through it without remarking on it. I asked the Echo what it smelled like. She said it smelled like the inside of a kettle, which I have remembered ever since because it was the right answer.

— EC

! **Laudare.**



CHAPTER II

Excavating Your Echo



Before you were Displaced, you had a singular, linear existence. You remember it as "ordinary", but that is just what singular and linear feel like when you have never known otherwise. I'm sorry that you will never know that comfort again.

This chapter is a recovery operation. Write down whatever you can, while you still can. Some of what I ask you for may already be gone. Mark the gaps. The shape of what's missing is still worth preserving.

THE PERSON YOU WERE

Write these down. You'll need them later — or you'll need to mourn them later:

NAME

Names are signals. The one your parents gave you carries the era they lived in, the language they spoke, the hopes and dreams they wanted for you. In a hundred years it may be the only piece of evidence you have that shows you came from anywhere at all.

Kalamander Gravedigger came from a different place than Bob Karl. Write the name that feels like it was yours.

ORIGIN ERA

When and where were you from. New York City, 2043, the apartment with the broken radiator on East 38th. Edo Japan, 1750, the field where your master beat you for sitting incorrectly. The Martian survivor colony in 3048, the year before the first collapse, when the progenerators first started screaming.

Be specific past the point of comfort. You aren't building a setting. You're putting down on paper the exact piece of reality you are about to spend this manual losing. Make it hurt to write. If it doesn't hurt, write it again.

THE DISPLACEMENT EVENT

What tore you out of the timestream. In my career I have documented displacements caused by experiments that should never have been authorized, by natural anomalies no one could have predicted, and by people who knew exactly what they were doing and proceeded anyway. Yours will fall into one of those, or a combination, or a fourth category I haven't yet identified. Maybe, it was my fault.

You may not remember. Many don't. Write *I cannot remember* and leave the space below it blank. Sometimes the memory comes back. Sometimes it comes back wrong. Sometimes the not-knowing is itself the event, and you only realize this several jumps later, when you notice that the shape of what you can't remember is the same shape as something else you've been avoiding.

THREE ORIGIN DETAILS

The person you felt the most passion for. The place you called home. The skill that you are most proud of. These three become your first Anchor Connections — the reference points your waveform will use when everything else has been reduced to static.

Passion isn't necessarily love. I met one Echo who vowed to go back and kill his partner for ruining a career-defining experiment. For most Echos, it is a parent, friend, partner or child - but even enemies can be defining if the flame burns hot enough.

The place you felt most as home isn't necessarily the place you "lived." For me, it was my lab.

Skills are things practiced when no one was watching. Whether it was Talmudic rhetoric, mastering medical equipment or woodcarving, your skill is arguably the only part of you that you chose for yourself.

YOUR TEMPORAL ANCHOR

An Anchor is Pascal's wager carved into an object. You commit to a person, a place, a promise, in full knowledge that you cannot verify the bet. If they exist, you have something to come home to. If they do not, you have lost nothing as you were already lost. — EC

— EC

A Reed-Solomon code can reconstruct a corrupted message if enough of the parity blocks survive. Your Anchor Connections function the same way. As long as enough remain, the original message — You — can be reconstructed from the fragments. Lose too many and all that's left is a stranger using your name. — EC

Your Anchor is your metaphysical connection to your origin — the reference frequency that keeps your waveform from dissolving completely into the timestream. It has two components.

ANCHOR STRENGTH

A rating from 1 to 5. You begin at Strength 3, which is deliberately mediocre. I tried starting new Echoes at Strength 5. They lost their Anchors faster than the ones who started at 3, because they had never learned what the strain felt like. So we start at 3 now.

Strength determines your maximum Wave Coherence: Strength + 5. At Strength 3 you cap at 8. If your Anchor Strength reaches 0, you suffer an Identity Crisis. I've been in the room for several of these, and I'd rather not discuss it now.

A number on a page pretending to be a soul.

ANCHOR CONNECTIONS

Specific, named connections to your Origin Era. These can be people (with names, relationships, and personal history), places (described by feeling as much as location), objects (physical items that travel with you), knowledge (personal expertise and skills), or events (experiences that seared themselves into your consciousness).

Write them with specificity. Not 'family' — write the specific child, the specific morning, the specific equipment you remember being relieved to see — 1 them without. Not 'work' — write the smell of burning coffee under the

The reason that example is generic is that Chen wrote it generic on purpose.

My daughter Sophie had a different version of that morning. Chen was in the room with me, taking notes, because that's what she does when she doesn't know what else to do with her hands. She wrote the example into this manual decades later and stripped it of the names. She thought I wouldn't notice.

I noticed.

—AR

Chen's sentimental about calling it structural.

I've maintained Anchor Strength 5 for three decades. It requires discipline. But a strong Anchor is the ultimate resistance to timeline corruption — it functions like gravitational mass in causality, the stronger the connection, the less the temporal current can push you.

— EC

I had Anchor Strength 5 for seventy years. Locked Memory. Perfect preservation protocols. Every Chen-approved technique in the playbook, executed with the kind of precision she'd give me a gold star for.

Then one morning I woke up and couldn't remember why I'd been trying so hard to remember.

The Anchor was still there — mechanically intact, fully functional, all the right boxes ticked. But the emotional resonance (what Chen calls μ , because of course she gave it a Greek letter) had degraded to zero. I was anchored to a ghost of a feeling about a place that might have existed, tied to a person whose face I could describe but no longer miss.

— 20 —

YOUR OPERATIONAL MODES

Modes are provisional. Please stop treating them like character classes.

She's right. They are classes. Just temporary ones.

Echoes approach the chaos of displacement through four instinctual Modes. Each has a rating from -1 to +3.

OBSERVE (+1): Perception. Analysis. Pattern recognition. Use this when you are studying a situation, searching for what is hidden, or planning before you move.

SYNC (+1): Empathy. Recognition. The reach across distance. Use this when you are trying to understand another person, trying to be understood, or trying to build something.

ENDURE (+1): Survival. Resistance. The capacity to keep going. Use this when the world is doing something to you and your job is not to break.

DISRUPT (+0): Disturbance. Violence. Paradox as tool. Use this when ruining something cleanly is the only path forward. *Be careful with this one.* — EC

These ratings represent your current state, not your character. As you change, so do they.

When multiple Modes could apply to an action, choose the one that reflects how your Echo is approaching the problem. Escaping pursuit by outlasting your pursuers is **ENDURE**. Escaping by finding a clever route is **OBSERVE**. Escaping by fighting through is **DISRUPT**. The Mode reflects your method, not just the category of action.

ACTION / MODE / REASON

| Action | Mode | Reason | |---|---|---| | Sneaking past guards | **OBSERVE** | finding the path and timing | | Blending into a crowd | **SYNC** | adapting to social context | | Picking a lock | **OBSERVE** | analyzing the mechanism | | Disguising yourself | **SYNC** | adopting a false identity | | Waiting in ambush | **ENDURE** | patience and stillness | | Interrogating someone | **SYNC** or **DISRUPT** | manipulation vs. intimidation | | Escaping pursuit | **ENDURE** or **OBSERVE** | stamina vs. finding the route | | Resisting torture | **ENDURE** | holding firm | | Lying convincingly | **SYNC** | social deception | | Fighting | **DISRUPT** | direct violence | | Analyzing technology | **OBSERVE** | understanding systems | | Calming a hostile NPC | **SYNC** | emotional navigation |

These categories bleed. Use your judgment. Where two tags could both apply, the more specific one wins. Where neither feels right, the situation is probably calling for a different Mode entirely. — EC

— EC

HOW MODES CHANGE (TEMPORAL ECHOES)

In Temporal Echoes, Modes shift through play — slowly, meaningfully, and at your discretion. They are not static stats. They are who you are right now.

You may adjust one Mode rating by 1 (up or down, minimum -1, maximum +3) when:

- You survive a Crisis and your approach to the world has visibly changed as a result
- A significant Memory is Lost and the absence reshapes how you operate (losing a Social memory might reduce **SYNC**; losing a Combat memory might reduce **DISRUPT**)
- You Lock a Memory and it crystallizes a particular capacity in you

When you change a Mode rating, write one sentence in your Chronicle explaining why. This is not bureaucracy. It is the game asking you to notice what you're becoming.

There is no ceiling on how far Modes can fall. An Echo who has lost every Combat memory and spent three years hiding may find their DISRUPT at -1. That is not a failure state. It is a true state.

YOUR FIVE STARTING MEMORIES

Memory is the substrate of identity. Cataloguing it is the most important act of preservation you will perform.

You begin with 5 Active Memories. Each represents a moment from before Displacement that shaped your competence. They won't last forever — they'll fade, then vanish, pushed out by new experiences as you travel. The question isn't whether you'll lose them. It's which ones go, and what you become without them.

For each Memory, write:

- **A Title** — brief and evocative, the way you'd refer to it in your head
- **Two Context Tags** — situations where this Memory's experience applies
- **A short description** — what happened, in your own voice

EXAMPLE MEMORY:

| *SAVING LIVES IN THE ER*

>

| *Tags: Medical Knowledge / Crisis Management*

>

| *The night I held a trauma patient's chest
together with my bare hands while we waited for
the surgeon. I know what calm looks like when
everything is going wrong.*

WHEN A MEMORY'S TAGS APPLY

A Memory applies when the current situation meaningfully resembles the Memory's context — not loosely, but genuinely. The test: could you confidently explain the connection to a skeptical friend? If yes, it applies. If you're reaching, it doesn't.

| Tag | Clearly Applies | Does Not Apply | |---|---|---| | Combat | Fighting, violence, threat assessment | Sneaking past guards without violence | | Medical | Treating wounds, diagnosis | Resisting poison (use Endurance) | | Engineering | Building, repairing, understanding | Using a machine normally | | Stealth | Hiding, moving unseen | Disguise (Social), lockpicking (Engineering) | | Investigation | Analyzing evidence, pattern recognition | Reading people (Social) | | Social | Persuasion, reading people, deception | Written communication | | Survival | Enduring hardship, finding resources | Urban navigation | | Historical Knowledge | Facts about eras, cultural context | Blending in socially (Social) | | Crisis Management | Staying calm under pressure, triage | Long-term planning |

EDGE CASES

- **'Reading the Room' (Investigation/Social)** — can you use this to calm a hostile stranger? Yes, if you're reading their emotional state to find an approach. No, if you're just trying to be friendly.
- **'Street Fighting' (Combat/Survival)** — can you use this for stealth? No. Survival covers enduring hardship, not moving unseen. You could use it for escaping after being spotted.
- **'The Breakthrough' (Research/Analysis)** — can you use this to analyze a person? Only if you're treating them like data — patterns, behaviors, inconsistencies. Not for emotional reads.

WHEN TWO TAGS COULD APPLY

Choose the one that better matches your approach. If you're sneaking by timing patrol patterns, that's Investigation (pattern recognition). If you're staying in shadows, that's Stealth. The Mode reflects your method.

CHOOSE TWO STARTING ASSETS

Choose two. They start fragile — Level 1, three Stress boxes before they break. You'll find the full specifications in Appendix B. Choose based on what you think will keep you alive. You will be wrong, but choose anyway.

CHRONO-TECH

- **Temporal Compass** — Detects anomalies, +1 **OBSERVE**
- **Memory Crystallizer** — Preserves Memories, +1 **ENDURE**
- **Resonance Dampener** — Resists Paradox, +1 **ENDURE**

ECHO TRAITS

- **Temporal Sensitivity** — Sense time flows, +1 **OBSERVE**
- **Adaptive Linguistics** — Learn languages instantly, +1 **SYNC**
- **Chronal Resilience** — Resist temporal damage, +1 **ENDURE**

TEMPORAL ANCHORS

- **Heirloom Object** — Physical tether, +1 **ENDURE**
- **Origin Era Knowledge** — Expertise from home time, +2 to relevant actions
- **Persistent Connection** — Recurring person or place across time

PUSHING AN ASSET

When you use an Asset during a roll, you may mark 1 Stress on that Asset to add +1 to your result after rolling. Once per roll. The Asset must be fictionally present or relevant — you're leaning on the tool, not invoking an abstract bonus. If you can't describe how the Asset helps in your Chronicle entry, you can't Push it.

When all Stress boxes on an Asset are marked, it becomes Glitched. A Glitched Asset still grants its base benefit, but if Pushed while Glitched, you must also accept a Complication. Glitched Assets must be repaired during Downtime.

NPC Records

When you meet someone significant — someone you'd risk something to save or kill, or who'd risk the same for you — create an NPC record in your Chronicle using this template:

NPC RECORD

Name: _____ Era: _____

Connection (how we met): _____

☐ They know I'm displaced ☐ I owe them ☐ They owe me

What they want: _____

What they fear: _____

RECURRING THREADS

When an NPC who matters to you is in danger, you may take the hit for them. Describe your intervention, then choose one cost: lose 1 Coherence, gain +1 Paradox, or mark 2 Stress on any Asset. If you pay that cost, they survive — and they become a Recurring Thread.

A Recurring Thread can appear in future eras without explanation. Timelines bend around people who matter. You don't need to justify how they're there. They're there because you made them matter.

Recurring Threads can become Anchor Connections. If one does, they follow all the rules for Anchor Connections — including the cost of invoking them, and the devastation of losing them.

There is no limit to the number of Recurring Threads you can have. The timeline bends around people who matter as many times as you're willing to pay the cost. Whether you can maintain those relationships across hundreds of years of displacement is a different question — one the Chronicle will answer honestly whether you want it to or not.

Your Initial State

Record your starting condition. Wave Coherence: +3. Paradox: 0. Five Active Memory slots — your starting Memories go here. Three Fading slots, empty. One Locked slot, empty and waiting for the Memory you decide matters most. This is who you are on paper. Paper lies, but it lies slowly.

Your Echo has been excavated. Open your Chronicle. Write your first entry: who you were, the moment of Displacement, and your first conscious thought in the timestream.

! *Experimenta moderata.*



CHAPTER III

A Session Of Play



OPENING THE SESSION

Before you write anything else, write down at least one question your Echo is trying to find out the answer to right now.

B This question is your compass. A scene that answers it — partly, badly, ambiguously — is a scene that did its job. Examples I see often: *Can I trust this professor? What happened to my daughter in this timeline? Why does this era feel wrong? What are the Factions hiding here?*

Not what they want to achieve. What they need to understand. A question, not a goal. This question is your compass for the session. When a scene answers it — even partially, even badly — that scene is complete.

Examples: Can I trust this professor? What happened to my daughter in this timeline? Why does this era feel wrong? What are the Factions hiding here?

FRAMING A SCENE

A scene begins when your Echo wants something specific from a specific person or place. To frame it, answer three things in your Chronicle:

Where am I? Use your established Era and Location, or roll a new

Location if you've moved.

Who's here? An NPC from a previous session, a new character from an

oracle, or no one.

What do I want from them? Information, safe passage, a moment of peace, to hurt them, to save them.

If you don't know what your Echo wants, roll on the Action Oracle and ask: what is the situation demanding of me?

WHEN TO ROLL

Three conditions decide whether to roll. The Echo wants the thing badly enough to risk something getting it. The outcome is uncertain. And failure would change the story in a way you'd want to write down.

When all three are present, roll. When any is missing, just write what happens. That said, If you don't give the Chronoverse a chance to push back on you regularly, it will end up taking from you catastrophically.

Pick up the dice. Name the action. Choose the Mode that matches how you're trying to survive it — **OBSERVE** to read the room, **SYNC** to bend to it, **ENDURE** to outlast it, **DISRUPT** to break it. If a Memory matches the context, let it guide you.

Note: if the current situation resonates with a Memory strongly enough that the past is actively informing your present, you may be able to invoke it for a deeper bonus — see 'Temporal Echoes: When the Past Bleeds Through' in Chapter 5 for the full procedure.

10+ COMPLETE SUCCESS

You achieve your goal cleanly. Gain +1 Wave Coherence.

7-9 SUCCESS WITH COMPLICATION

You succeed, but there's a cost, twist, or new problem. Coherence unchanged.

6- FAILURE WITH OPPORTUNITY

You fail, but discover something useful or a new path opens. Lose 1 Coherence OR mark 1 Paradox (your choice).

Record it all. The Chronicle is the only proof you were ever here.

One of my favorite lies in this whole manual. You rolled a 12, congratulations. Reality bends for you. You feel synchronized. Chen calls this Complete Success.

I call it Borrowed Time.

Because I've rolled 10+ on Navigation a dozen times, landed exactly where I wanted, felt that sweet surge of Coherence — and then watched the timeline I just successfully navigated collapse three weeks later because I didn't understand what I was aligning with.

Your dice said success. The Chronoverse is still deciding.

—AR

ENDING A SCENE

A scene ends when: you get what you wanted (success, clean or complicated), you clearly don't get what you wanted (failure), or the situation changes so completely that a new want replaces the old one.

When the scene ends, write in your Chronicle: what changed? And what question are you carrying into the next scene?

MOVING BETWEEN SCENES

Ask: do I stay here, or go somewhere else? If you stay, the next scene happens in the same location — moments or hours later. Something has changed. If you go, decide where. If you're leaving the era entirely, that's a Navigation roll (see below) or forced displacement.

CLOSING THE SESSION

A session ends when you've answered your opening question (or learned it cannot be answered here), you've played for one to three hours and feel a natural pause, or a Crisis forces a major change that ends the current chapter of your story. Then perform Downtime.

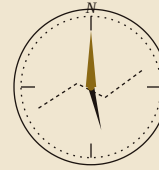
Before you close the book, answer your opening question in your Chronicle — even if the answer is 'I couldn't find out' or 'I found out and wish I hadn't.' Then write what that answer makes you need to know next.

The loop: open with a question, close by answering it, let the answer generate the next question. Each session is a closed loop that opens another. Do not aim for a specific number of scenes. You are done when the question has an answer.

Turing proved that no algorithm can determine, in general, whether an arbitrary program will halt. Navigation has a similar problem. There is no procedure that can tell you, in advance, whether a Jump will resolve cleanly or fragment you. You roll, you commit, you find out. The undecidability is a fundamental property of time in the Chronoverse. — EC

> **Volve, Nota et Memento.*

— EC



CHAPTER IV

Core Resolution & Faction Pressure



THE RESOLUTION ROLL

When the outcome matters, you roll. Two six-sided dice, plus the relevant Mode, plus your Memory bonus if one applies.

10+ is success. 7-9 is success with cost. 6- is failure with an opening.

I want to say something about the 6- before we go further. New Echoes treat it as the bad result. It isn't. The 10+ ends the question; the 6- changes it. Both move the story. Only one of them surprises you.

— EC

When you attempt something risky or opposed, make a Resolution Roll:

W RESOLUTION

Roll: 2d6 + Mode Rating + Memory Bonus

- 10+ Complete Success —achieve goal, +1 Wave Coherence
- 7-9 Success with Complication —succeed, cost or new problem
- 6- Failure with Opportunity —fail, but gain something useful

Choose: Lose 1 Coherence OR Mark 1 Paradox

MEMORY BONUS

Active Memory matching context +2 Fading Memory matching context +1 Locked Memory matching context +3 No relevant Memory +0

NAVIGATION

You will be displaced whether you want to be or not. Faction interference, Crisis events, and temporal instability will throw you between eras involuntarily. But you can also attempt Precision Navigation — using resonance principles to target specific coordinates in time.

PRECISION NAVIGATION

When you attempt to reach a specific era or location:

Step 1: Define Your Target. Specify as precisely as you can — when (year, decade, or century), where (city, region, or continent), and why (what you're seeking there, which helps focus the resonance).

Your precision affects the Difficulty:

TARGET PRECISION DIFFICULTY

Specific date & location (June 23, 1848, 12 Rue Saint-Jacques, Paris) Year & city (1848, Paris) 10 Decade & region (1840s, France) 8 Century & continent (1800s, Europe) 7

Step 2: Pay the Cost. Spend 1 Coherence before rolling. When you have 0 Coherence, you cannot attempt Precision Navigation.

Step 3: Roll 2d6 + **OBSERVE** + Memory Bonus (if applicable).

Step 4: Read the result:

12+ **PERFECT RESONANCE**
Arrive exactly when and where intended. Gain +1 Coherence (clean synchronization). No Paradox generated.

10-11 **SUCCESSFUL NAVIGATION**
Arrive at intended era and location. Minor variance (different street, day off by a week). Mark +1 Paradox from resonance strain.

7-9 **CLOSE ARRIVAL**
Arrive in correct era OR correct location, not both. Same year, different city, OR same city, years off. Mark +1 Paradox.

6- **LOST IN TRANSIT**
Navigation fails. Consult the Anomaly Tables (see below). Choose: Lose 1 Coherence OR Mark +2 Paradox.

STRUCTURED CORRECTION

After rolling all four Anomaly Tables, you may spend 1 Coherence to reroll one result. Choose which table to reroll (**ERA**, **LOCATION**, **ANOMALY**, or **COMPLICATION**), spend the Coherence, and accept the new result. You may do this once per displacement event.

Initial observations can contain measurement error. Temporal resonance creates interference. If you invest the Coherence to recalibrate, you can refine your assessment. This isn't changing reality. It's correcting your perception of what exists.

— EC

Chen's into spending Coherence to make the dice lie more comfortably. Sure, it works. It's also false comfort.

—AR

NAVIGATION COLLAPSE (PARADOX 7+)

At Paradox 7 or higher, your waveform is too unstable for resonance-targeting. You have lost fine control.

AT PARADOX **7+**: NAVIGATION COLLAPSE

You cannot roll Precision Navigation.

State your intention ('I'm trying to reach 1848 Paris').

All displacement is determined by the Anomaly Tables.

Structured Correction still applies.

To restore Precision Navigation, reduce Paradox below 7.

Chen frames it as agency vs. passivity. She's way offbase. The only choice is between paying for the illusion of control and admitting you don't have any. Anomaly Tables are cheaper because they're not selling you anything.

— 39 —

—AR

WAVE COHERENCE

Coherence is the integrity of your harmonic signature. It holds you to a single line of self when everything around you is trying to dissolve you into static. It is the most expensive resource you have and one you will spend without noticing you spent it.

Track Coherence on a scale from +6 to -6. Each value corresponds to a state you can feel — if you have the discipline to feel it before you've already passed it.

— EC

Wave Coherence measures how aligned you are with the timestream. It ranges from -6 to your Anchor Strength + 5 (usually 8).

COHERENCE STATE EFFECT

Synchronized (+6 to +8) +1 to all Resolution rolls. You move through time with grace.

Flux (0 to +5) No modifier. Normal operation.

Desynchronizing (-1 to -5) -1 to all Resolution rolls. Time is hostile.

Crisis (-6) -2 to all Resolution rolls. Immediate Desynchronization Crisis.

GAINING AND LOSING COHERENCE

You gain Coherence when you succeed (+1 on a 10+), when you write something true in your Chronicle (+1), when you reinforce your Anchor (+2). You lose it when you fail (-1 on a 6-, or choose Paradox instead), when you're Displaced (see Displacement Costs below), when you let a Memory fade (-1), when your Anchor takes Stress (see Anchor Stress below). The math is simple. The choices aren't.

— 40 —

DISPLACEMENT COSTS

Every time you are Displaced — voluntarily or not — you lose Coherence from the wrenching dislocation.

DISPLACEMENT TYPE COHERENCE COST

Precision Navigation (voluntary) -1 (paid before rolling)

Failed Navigation (6-) -1 or +2 Paradox (your choice)

Forced Displacement — Faction interference, -2

Crisis, random jump

Crisis Displacement — Shattering, Identity -3

collapse, Breach

Involuntary jumps always cost 2. Crisis-level displacement costs 3. You don't get to choose when those happen. That's the point.

ANCHOR STRESS

Your Anchor is not invulnerable. Certain events put direct pressure on your connection to your origin — not enough to break it, but enough to require maintenance.

Your Anchor has a Stress track: ○○○

MARK 1 ANCHOR STRESS WHEN:

A Church Templar successfully captures or touches you (their rituals target your origin frequency directly)

You fail a roll involving your Locked Memory while in

Desynchronization Crisis (-1 to -5 Coherence)

You spend Downtime in an era that directly contradicts a core Anchor Connection (you knew her as alive; here she died before you were born)

A Crisis outcome specifies Anchor Stress

When all 3 Anchor Stress boxes are marked, your Anchor is Strained. While Strained: you cannot invoke Anchor Connections for Coherence bonuses. The Reinforce Anchor move (Ch. 7) clears Stress as normal — but on a 6-, you lose 1 Anchor Strength permanently instead of just failing.

Clear Anchor Stress during Downtime Step 2.

COHERENCE OVERFLOW

When you would gain Coherence but are already at your maximum, choose one: Stabilize an Asset (clear 1 Stress from any Asset), Reduce Contamination (reduce Paradox by 1, if above 0), or Bank It (mark +1 Banked Coherence, maximum 3 Banked). Spend Banked Coherence 1-for-1 to prevent Coherence loss.

This mechanic exists in Temporal Echoes only. Wrecks do not bank Coherence. You're not preserving anything.

PARADOX: THE UNIVERSE PUSHING BACK

Paradox accumulates through interference. The universe keeps count even when you don't.

ACTION PARADOX

Contradict your own Chronicle +1

Share knowledge from the wrong era (a technique, a fact, a warning) +1

Change something small — redirect one person, save one life, +1

alter one decision

Change something documented — an event with witnesses, +2

a death with records

Create a causal loop (you caused the thing that caused you here) +2

Meet yourself (any version — past, future, alternate) +2

Change something load-bearing — a battle's outcome, +3

a discovery's timing, a leader's survival

Cause a Shattering deliberately +3

When in doubt: if people would write it down afterward, it's +2. If people would change how they understand history, it's +3. If only you noticed, it's +1.

PARADOX BAND EFFECTS

Shadow (0-3) — No penalties. Small reality glitches: déjà vu, objects slightly wrong. Invisible to Factions.

Flux (4-6) — -1 to Resolution rolls. Noticeable anomalies. Memory Fading accelerates. Faction Scouts appear when you roll 6-.

Anomaly (7-9) — -1 to Resolution rolls. Memory Fading doubles. Reality actively hostile. Faction Agents appear as complication on 7-9.

Breach (10+) — -2 to Resolution rolls. Timeline collapsing. Immediate Paradox Crisis. Faction Intervention during Crisis Phase 2.

The modifiers above are designed to compound. So are the modifiers from Coherence states, Faction Marks, and unfavored Modes. At low Paradox and stable Coherence, the math is forgiving. At high Paradox and Crisis Coherence, it is hostile. This is deliberate. I will say more about it in Chapter 6.

What you should know now: when the stack turns against you, better dice will not save you. The systems the game has been holding in reserve will. Engage them.

— EC

FACTION PRESSURE

You are a foreign object in a closed system. The Chronoverse has an immune response, and your Paradox is the fever it is responding to. The Factions are antibodies with philosophies. Containment, harvest, euthanasia — none of these are moral failures on their part, and accepting an Offer is not a moral failure on yours. They are not after you because they hate you. They are after you because you are fuel.

— EC

SHADOW (0-3): INVISIBLE

You're background noise. Factions have no reason to notice something they can't measure. Enjoy it. It won't last.

FLUX (4-6): SCOUTS APPEAR

When you roll 6-, a Scout appears. Roll **d4**: 1 = Church Observer, 2 = Authority Surveyor, 3 = Scionfall Herald, 4 = Chronoclast. Automatic if you're already Marked. Scouts watch. They file reports. They don't act — they're waiting to see if you're worth the effort.

ANOMALY (7-9): AGENTS APPEAR

When you roll 7-9, a Faction Agent appears as your complication. They've decided you're worth the effort. They make an Offer. Roll **d4** for which Faction, or automatic if Marked. This is when the game changes.

BREACH (10+): INTERVENTION

During Crisis Phase 2, Factions arrive in force. You're not a nuisance anymore. You're a crisis event. Roll **d4**, or **d4** twice for a Factional War — two Factions competing over what to do with you. See Crisis Interventions in Chapter 6.

AGENT ENCOUNTERS

When an Agent appears at Paradox **7-9**, they bring an Offer. The form varies — surveillance, interference, demand, or direct confrontation. Not every Agent encounter is a fight.

You choose one of three responses:

1. Accept the Offer. Pay the cost, gain the benefit. Offers are trades, not rolls.
2. Refuse. They impose a consequence and Mark you.
3. Drive Off. Make a roll to force them away.

Offers are your non-roll path to Paradox relief. If Downtime moves aren't working, an Agent's trade is how you buy back control — by selling pieces of yourself.

THE DRIVE OFF MOVE

Roll **2d6 + DISRUPT (Difficulty 10)**:

10+ Success. You drive them off through violence or intimidation. No additional cost. They retreat. You're not Marked.

7-9 Success with cost. They retreat. Choose one: lose 2 Coherence, mark +1 Paradox, or they Mark you anyway.

6- Failure. You fail. Take their Imposed consequence AND they Mark you. They leave when they're done with you.

THE FOUR AGENTS

The four below are not exhaustive. They are the four I have met often enough to describe consistently. Each Faction has variations — older Templars, younger Auditors, Heralds wearing a face you have not yet lost, Chronoclasts who have learned restraint. The descriptions are what holds across the variations. The faces change. The function does not.

— EC

1. CHURCH TEMPLAR

They appear bleeding through their era-appropriate armor, chronoglyphs inscribed into the metal. The thing you notice first are their eyes — millennia of pain mixed with purpose and pleasure.

The Offer: Your pain can have purpose. Let us use it.

The Trade: Take 1 Scar immediately + lose 2 Coherence → Reduce Paradox by 3. Mark: Church knows you're a viable battery. They'll return.

If Refused: Impose — their prayer weighs on you, lose 1 Coherence. Mark — next Scout/Agent encounter is automatically Church.

2. AUTHORITY AUDITOR

Forgettable in the way that only deliberate design achieves. A grey suit that wears a human being. Takes notes. Blinks and their clothes change slightly.

The Offer: You're glitching. We can smooth you out. Become efficient again.

The Trade: Choose one Active Memory — it becomes normalized (bonus drops from +2 to +0, emotional context erased). → Reduce Paradox by 2, clear 1 Stress from one Asset. Mark: They've tagged your waveform.

If Refused: Impose — -1 to Navigation rolls until next Downtime. Mark — they begin preparing a Clone Loop.

3. SCIONFALL HERALD

They always appear as a loved one. Kind eyes, warm voice, something underneath that is steel all the way through.

The Offer: I can end the pain. All of it. Right now.

The Trade: Character retired. You cease. Peacefully. Game over. Write a final Chronicle entry: I let go. This is a valid ending — choosing peace over continued suffering.

If Refused: Impose — -1 to **ENDURE** while they're present. Mark — the offer stands, always. They'll return during your next Crisis.

4. CHRONOCLAST REMIXER

Anachronism incarnate. Carrying objects from the wrong era. Laughing at things that aren't funny.

The Offer: You're making art! Here — let's make it louder.

The Trade: Gain +2 Paradox now → Gain +3 to your next DISRUPT or **OBSERVE** roll only. Regardless of result, that roll triggers a Complication. Mark: they think you're interesting.

If Refused: Impose — roll on Timeline Shift Oracle immediately (reality changes around you). Mark — they'll bring a gift next time (unstable Chrono-Tech that glitches constantly).

BEING MARKED

When a Faction Marks you, write in your Chronicle: MARKED: [Faction name]. The next time that Faction would appear, they appear automatically — no **d4** roll needed. Once they appear, erase the Mark. You can be Marked by multiple Factions simultaneously.

Being Marked doesn't mean immediate danger — it means they're watching. They know your resonance signature now. You've become a bookmark in their archives.

— EC

Being Marked means you're screwed. You drew their attention, refused their offer, and now they know you're worth effort. I've been Marked by all four Factions simultaneously. It's like having four different kinds of cancer. Each one convinced they're helping.

—AR

DOWNTIME

Downtime is the part of the work nobody else does for you. When a session ends, or when the era is briefly not actively trying to kill you, stop and write down what happened. Repair what you can. Many good Echoes faded because they did not take Downtime with the rigor it deserves.

— EC

WHEN TO TAKE DOWNTIME

After every Precision Navigation roll, OR

After every Oracle Displacement (rolling all four Anomaly Tables), OR

At the end of your real-world play session, if neither of the above occurred.

DOWNTIME STEPS (DO THESE IN ORDER)

1. Chronicle the Session.

Write in your Chronicle: where/when you are, what happened this session, one significant choice you made, one thing you lost or changed. This is mandatory. Chronicling is how you stabilize memory. Effect: gain +1 Coherence, up to your maximum.

1. Reinforce Your Anchor.

If your Anchor took Stress during the session, roll **2d6 + SYNC (Difficulty 10)**. On **10+**: clear all Stress. On **7-9**: clear 1 Stress, and either spend time and resources on it or leave remaining Stress. On **6-**: no Stress cleared.

1. Tend to Assets.

For each Asset with Stress marked, roll **2d6** + relevant Mode (usually **OBSERVE** for tech, **SYNC** for connections). On **10+**: clear all Stress. On **7-9**: clear 1 Stress. On **6-**: no Stress cleared. If an Asset has all Stress marked, it's broken — spend a Downtime move repairing it (narrate the work, no roll) or replace it with a new Asset at Level 1.

1. Process Memory.

Your memory system naturally degrades. The oldest Active Memory moves to Fading (loses +2 bonus, now +1). The oldest Fading Memory becomes Lost. When a Memory becomes Lost, gain a Scar (see Chapter 5).

When a memory passes from Active to Fading, you notice it as effort — the thing you used to recall instantly now requires you to reach. Fading to Lost is quieter. You don't notice the moment it goes. You notice, weeks later, that something used to be there and now is not. You reach for the cup that isn't there. You start the sentence and find no end to it. The Scar is the shape the absence leaves.

Your Locked Memory never fades.

If something significant happened this session, you may create a new Memory: write the event, choose Context Tags, write a description. It enters Active Slot 1, pushing everything else forward.

1. Reduce Paradox (Optional).

CHOOSE ONE:

Temporal Grounding: Spend significant time integrating with the current era. Roll **2d6** + **SYNC** (**Difficulty 10**). On **10+**: reduce Paradox by 2. On **7-9**: reduce by 1. On **6-**: no reduction, lose 1 Coherence from the exhaustion.

Ritual Purification: Use specialized Chrono-Tech or Faction assistance. Effect: reduce Paradox by **1d6**, but if using Church methods, take 1 Mutation; if using Authority methods, normalize 1 Scar (reduce bonus to +0); if using tech, the Asset takes all Stress.

Ignore: Accept your current contamination level.

1. Plan Next Move.

Answer one of these questions in your Chronicle: What am I trying to accomplish? What am I afraid will happen next? What do I need that I don't have?

SAFETY TOOLS

This game explores identity dissolution, memory loss, isolation, and the horror of losing yourself piece by piece.

The Temporal Pause (X-Card): At any point, if the content becomes too intense, stop writing. Close the Chronicle. Breathe. Narratively, your Echo phases out of local time for a micro-second, avoiding the trauma. Mechanically, skip the scene. No penalty. Reality redraws itself around the gap.

Lines and Veils: Lines are events that don't happen in your timeline — write them in the back of your Chronicle under Redacted Data. If an Oracle prompts them, reroll. Veils are events that happen off-screen — describe the setup and aftermath, but the event itself is Lost to Static.

EXPANDED SAFETY TOOLS

Temporal Echoes is a game about loss, memory, and identity erosion. Played at length, it will put you in proximity to real feelings you may not have scheduled time for. The following tools exist to help you engage with difficult material without getting genuinely hurt.

LINES AND VEILS

Before your first session, take ten minutes to write two short lists in the front of your Chronicle.

Lines — content that will not appear in your game, ever. Hard stops. If the Oracle rolls toward it, you reroll or narrate around it. There is no mechanical cost for this. The game's rules have no authority over what you're willing to encounter.

Veils — content that may exist in the world of the game but is not described on-page. Violence happens, but you don't zoom in on it. A character dies, but you cut to the next scene. Fade to black is a legitimate move.

Your Lines and Veils can change between sessions. Cross things out. Add new ones. You are not locked in.

THE TEMPORAL PAUSE (X-CARD EQUIVALENT)

At any point, if the content of the scene is genuinely affecting you in a way you didn't sign up for — not uncomfortable-in-a-good-way, not sad-about-fictional-things, but actually-bad-for-you — close the book. Stand up. Walk away.

The game does not require completion. Your Echo does not lose Coherence because you put the book down. A session you stopped is a session. You can come back, or you can choose not to. Both are legal.

FAST FORWARD

If a scene is going somewhere you'd rather not dwell — an interrogation, a captivity vignette, a loss of a specific Anchor Connection — you may narrate through it in a single paragraph and move on. Record only the outcome. Pay any mechanical costs. Do not detail the content.

This is not cheating. The mechanics work the same. You just don't linger.

REWIND

If you make a narrative choice and, an hour later, realize it sent the story somewhere you don't want to go, you may Rewind. Cross out the last paragraph of your Chronicle. Return to the prior decision point. Choose differently.

Pay the mechanical costs of any rolls that occurred. Keep any Scars. The fiction is yours to revise. The accumulated damage is not.

PROCESSING DIFFICULT CONTENT

Temporal Echoes deliberately engages with memory loss, grief, identity dissolution, and the specific horror of outliving your own ability to feel things. The game was built by someone processing their own experience of these, and many of the people who play it are doing the same. A few practices that help if you are one of them.

Decouple the Echo from yourself. Name them something other than your own name. Give them an origin era you did not live in. The distance is what makes the catharsis possible without it bleeding into your actual life.

Keep a separate notebook — not the Chronicle — for one line per session about how the session affected you. Not how it affected your Echo. This is not part of the game. It is part of being a person who plays the game.

If a session leaves you raw, talk to a person who exists in your life before you pick the book up again. The Chronicle is a mirror, and a mirror is not the same thing as company.

A NOTE ON CRISIS

If you are in genuine mental-health crisis — the kind that does not belong in a game — please set the book aside and contact a crisis line in your region, or a trusted person. The game will still be here. You need to be too.

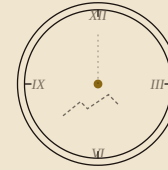
Gödel proved that any formal system rich enough to express arithmetic contains true statements it cannot prove. Reality, under CTH, is the same. There are facts about the timeline that are true and that the timeline cannot accommodate. Echoes bear those facts carved into their identity, but Paradox is what happens when an unprovable truth tries to find a place to stand.

— EC

Chen calls them an immune system. Cute framing. An immune system protects the body. The factions don't protect anything. They digest you and call the digestion mercy, order, freedom, art. Pick your enzyme.

—AR

! Memoria finita est.



CHAPTER V

Memory Management



THE ARCHITECTURE OF SELF

When memory fails, identity collapses. Collapses start small. First, the Echo can't remember *why* they were trying to remember while writing, then they can't remember what the chronicle is for, and eventually, they can't remember themselves.

Sometimes there are pieces of the old person in the rubble. Those pieces are valuable, but they aren't the person before the collapse.

Nine slots. Five Active. Three Fading. One Locked. The structure reflects what your nervous system was already doing before you were Displaced. You never remembered everything you lived. You remembered what was worth the metabolic cost of remembering.

The Chronoverse imposes the same accounting on Echoes, except the cost is steeper and the negotiation is shorter. Without intervention, the cost wins. With intervention, the cost still wins, but more slowly, and you get to choose what pieces you lose first.

Your memories exist in four states. They will not stay where you put them.

ACTIVE MEMORIES (5 SLOTS)

Vivid, detailed, present in your mind. These provide +2 to matching actions. They're energetically expensive to maintain — high-amplitude waveforms with strong emotional mass. When you invoke an Active Memory for a bonus, you're literally harmonizing with your past self, using stored resonance to enhance your current action.

FADING MEMORIES (3 SLOTS)

Losing clarity. +1 to matching actions. One step from being Lost. The signal is still there, but noise is increasing — new memories broadcasting on similar frequencies, creating static that obscures the old ones. The amplitude is decreasing. Chen's model calls this entropy. She's half right. It's also interference.

LOCKED MEMORY (1 SLOT)

Permanently preserved. +3 to matching actions. Costs 3 Coherence to Lock. Cannot fade through normal means. You're spending tremendous energy to create a standing wave — a self-reinforcing pattern that resists entropy.

Locking is the most important choice you'll make. Choose a Memory that defines your core identity — something that, if lost, would mean you no longer recognize yourself. You can only Lock once.

*I Locked the memory of Sarah's birth. The science worked.
The memory is still mechanically intact 340 years later.*

*What Chen's equations don't account for: Emotional Mass
(μ isn't constant. It decays.*

*You can preserve the structure — the date, the hospital
room, the factual details. But the feeling? The love? The
specific quality of consciousness that made you care?*

That has a half-life she's never calculated.

*Memory Locking preserves the skeleton. The soul rots
anyway.*

This is the equation Chen doesn't write:

Memory Coherence = Structure $\times$ (Emotional Mass $\times e^{(-t/\tau)}$)

Where τ is the decay constant and t is subjective time.

*Lock all the memories you want. Time will hollow them out.*⁵⁸

LOST MEMORIES

Gone from conscious mind. No bonus. They leave Scars — narrative consequences, behavioral changes, the shape of what used to be there.

THE CYCLE OF FORGETTING

When you experience something significant enough to form a new Memory:

1. Create the Memory: write title, tags, description.
2. It enters Active Slot 1.
3. The oldest Active Memory is pushed to Fading.
4. The oldest Fading Memory becomes Lost.

You form roughly **1-2** new Memories per session. The pressure to choose what matters is the game.

TRIGGERS FOR NEW MEMORIES

New Memories form when something breaks the pattern — when you survive a Crisis, achieve something that costs you, connect with someone who matters, or simply decide that this moment is the one. The last trigger is the most important. You decide what defines you. The timestream doesn't get a vote.

SCARS: WHAT REMAINS

When a Memory becomes Lost, its emotional residue remains as a Scar — a psychological wound or changed behavior. When a Memory goes, something stays in its shape. Choose the wound:

Phantom Habit: you perform a ritual you don't understand. The body remembers what the mind has lost.

False Story: you've constructed a lie to fill the gap. You believe

it. That's the dangerous part.

Persistent Ache: physical pain tied to the loss. Location unknown.

Cause unverifiable.

Emotional Void: numbness where feeling used to be, or feeling where numbness would be appropriate.

Behavioral Shift: a personality change, permanent. You act differently now. You may not have noticed yet.

Scars accumulate. Track them in your Chronicle. For more specific shapes of deterioration, see Appendix G: Temporal Pathologies.

SCARS VS. MUTATIONS: A CRITICAL DISTINCTION

Scars are identity consequences — psychological wounds gained when a Memory becomes Lost. Mutations are reality consequences — gained only from Paradox Breach (reaching 10+) or from explicit Mutation triggers in Faction interactions and Crisis outcomes.

Scars are what you lose. Mutations are what the Chronoverse makes you become.

Scars are the shape of what you've lost. They are your own psyche rewriting itself around an absence. Mutations are the shape of what the Chronoverse has made you. They are the timestream writing itself onto your body. One is grief. The other is contamination. Both are permanent.

MUTATIONS (TEMPORAL ECHOES)

When you gain a Mutation — from Paradox Breach, from a Faction trade, from a Crisis outcome that specifies it — choose one from this list, or create your own in the same register. These are not personality quirks. They are the Chronoverse writing itself onto your body.

Temporal Stutter — Time skips for you. You occasionally repeat the last few seconds of your own life, experiencing them twice. You are aware the second time. No one else is. You have no control over when this happens. Mechanically: once per session, the Oracle may declare your most recent roll occurred twice — both results stand, and you must narrate both.

Echo Bleed — You see brief overlays of other timelines. Strangers' faces flicker. Buildings appear half-demolished. You cannot always tell what is the present. Mechanically: -1 to **OBSERVE** when you have no Memory that applies to the current situation. The static fills the gap where context should be.

Displaced Affect — Your emotional responses have decoupled from their causes. You laugh at grief. You feel nothing at danger. You cry at sunsets. People notice. Mechanically: -1 to **SYNC** with anyone who has witnessed a Crisis involving you. They don't know what to make of you. They're not wrong to be unsettled.

Temporal Scarring — Wounds you sustained in other timelines manifest on your body in this one. Old injuries reopen. Scar tissue that wasn't there yesterday is there now. Mechanically: whenever you take a Crisis consequence that involves physical damage, it costs +1 additional Coherence. The body keeps its own accounting.

Signal Intrusion — You receive transmissions from other versions of yourself — fragments of choices you didn't make, warnings that may or may not apply to your current timeline. They feel urgent. They are sometimes wrong. Mechanically: once per session, you may ask the Action Oracle a yes/no question about the immediate future. The Oracle answers. Whether to trust it is your problem.

Anchor Drift — Your emotional connection to your origin has started to migrate. The people you think you're trying to return to are blurring with people you've met since. You're not sure which memories are original and which are composites. Mechanically: during Downtime, when you write a Chronicle entry about your Anchor Connections, roll **1d6**. On a 1, one Anchor Connection detail shifts slightly — not lost, but changed. Record both versions. You don't know which one is real.

PRESERVATION MOVES

LOCK MEMORY (3 COHERENCE)

Permanently preserve one Active Memory. Can only be done once. Choose the core of your identity — the memory you would die before forgetting. Provides +3 bonus when invoked. Cannot fade through normal means.

REINFORCE MEMORY (1 COHERENCE PER SCENE)

Keep one Active Memory from fading this cycle. Requires narrating how you actively recall or relive it. Temporary protection — must be renewed each Downtime.

RECOVER LOST MEMORY (3 COHERENCE, ROLL ENDURE, DIFFICULTY 12)

You make a desperate attempt to dredge a Lost Memory from the void. This is not remembering — it's excavation. Spend 3 Coherence. Name the Lost Memory you are trying to recover. Then roll **2d6 + ENDURE** against **Difficulty 12**.

12+ Against all odds, it returns. The Memory enters an Active slot, pushing all others down — this may force another Memory to become Fading. Gain +1 Paradox from the strain on causality.

10-11 A fragment returns. The Memory comes back as Fading. You remember the shape of it, but not the texture. Gain +1 Paradox.

7-9 The effort fails. Lose 1 additional Coherence. The Memory is gone. This attempt is the last time you'll look for it.

6- The void stares back. You recover a False Memory — a comforting lie that fills the gap. The Oracle decides what it is. You believe it completely. Gain a Scar: Beautiful Lie.

THE CHRONICLE SYSTEM

The Chronicle is your character's literal survival mechanism. Without it, memory loss accelerates catastrophically. It is not flavoring. It is load-bearing.

WHAT TO RECORD

Record the date and location of each era as precisely as you can determine. Record the events that changed you and the people who caused them. Track your Memory status, your Coherence, your Paradox. Write down what happened during Crises. If you have time — and you will not always have time — record the sensory details. What it smelled like. What it sounded like. These details are the difference between remembering and merely knowing.

CHRONICLE BONUSES

Detailed Entries grant +1 Coherence once per session, when your entry: describes a scene in vivid detail, reflects on your emotional state, connects to your Anchor or Memories, and advances your understanding of your condition.

Reference Bonus: When facing a situation similar to a previous encounter, read the relevant past Chronicle entries. Gain +1 to the Resolution roll if past experience genuinely applies.

Temporal Echoes: When the Past Bleeds Through

Sometimes, in moments of Crisis or revelation, the weight of all your past experiences presses upon the present. A decision made centuries ago influences your actions now. This is not metaphor. This is CTH.

When you make a Resolution Roll, if the current situation resonates strongly with one of your Memories (Active, Fading, or Locked), you may invoke it:

1. State the Memory — identify the specific Memory in your Chronicle.
2. Explain the Connection — how this past experience provides genuine insight into the current situation.
3. Gain the Bonus — apply the bonus based on the Memory's status (Active +2, Fading +1, Locked +3).

Limits: one Memory per roll. Choose the most relevant. In Crisis state (Coherence -6 to -3), Echo bonuses are reduced by 1. The Memory must have a clear, explicable connection to the situation — if you're reaching, it doesn't apply.

[**CHRONICLE ENTRY FRAGMENT** — Found inserted between pages **47-48** of a recovered Chronicle, author unknown]

I followed every procedure. Every rule. Every preservation protocol in Chen's manual. I maintained Coherence above +5 for two centuries. I Locked my defining Memory. I reinforced my Anchor quarterly. I wrote in the Chronicle every single day.

And this morning I read my first entry. The one I wrote on Day 1, right after Displacement. The one where I described my lab, my daughter, my life.

I didn't recognize it.

Not that I'd forgotten — the mechanics were intact, the Memory was still Active. But reading those words felt like reading someone else's diary. The person who wrote that entry cared about those things. The person reading it now... doesn't.

The Chronicle preserved everything Chen said it would. It just couldn't preserve the person who cared about preserving it.

I think that might be the joke.

(No signature. No date. The handwriting changes halfway through.)

The holographic principle holds that the information content of a volume of space can be encoded on its boundary. Your Chronicle is your boundary. What you write down is the surface from which your interior — your continuous self — can be reconstructed. If the volume is lost but the boundary remains, you can be rebuilt. — EC

— EC

Some dude named Derrida once said the trace is what survives the absence of presence. The Chronicle is the trace. You are not in the journal, Ellie. The journal is what's left after you. Stop confusing the corpse with the body.

—AR

! Crisis.



CHAPTER VI

Crisis Management



Crises come in three phases.

Manifestation is the moment you recognize what is happening. Your chest tightening, the room narrowing. The feeling that the floor is not where you left it. You have a window — small, closing — to act before the body and the timeline both decide for you.

Escalation is when the system commits. You can no longer stop the cascade through will alone. You can spend resources to direct it, but that is about it. The water is rising; the question is which way you swim, not whether you can stay dry.

Resolution is what is left. You survive or you don't. You return changed or you do not return at all.

Three Crises live in this chapter. Each has its own physics. All three feel the same in the first thirty seconds.

— EC

DESYNCHRONIZATION CRISIS (COHERENCE -6)

You've lost synchronization with the timestream. Trigger: Coherence drops to -6. Manifestation: roll on the Temporal Anomaly table — reality fractures around you.

PARADOX CRISIS (PARADOX 10+)

Timeline contradictions reach critical mass. Trigger: Paradox reaches 10. Manifestation: roll on the Timeline Collapse table — history rewrites itself.

IDENTITY CRISIS (ANCHOR STRENGTH 0)

Your connection to your origin has severed. Trigger: Anchor Strength drops to 0. Manifestation: you don't know who you are.

When your Paradox reaches critical mass, you're not just causing problems. You're creating topological stress in the causal field. Reality can no longer absorb your contradictions smoothly.

The most dangerous state isn't when timelines are far apart. It's when they're forced to almost touch, almost reconcile — and can't. That's when reality shatters.

A Shattering isn't the timeline breaking. It's topological bifurcation — reality splitting into multiple causally-disjoint eigenstates. The original timeline ceases to exist, replaced by its fractured components.

This is survivable with proper Crisis management.

— EC

She never experienced a Shattering. I have. 37 times. I was the Shattering a couple of times.

The you reading this has survived at least one Shattering already. You just don't remember the timeline where you didn't make it.

— AR

CRISIS RESOLUTION PROCEDURE

PHASE 1: MANIFESTATION

1. Roll on the appropriate Oracle table.
2. Describe the Crisis erupting.
3. Pay the immediate cost: Desynchronization — mark 1 Asset Stress. Paradox — one Active Memory becomes Fading. Identity — lose access to one Asset temporarily.

PHASE 2: ESCALATION

The Crisis intensifies.

1. Roll on the Timeline Shifts Oracle to determine how reality changes.
2. Roll on the Action Oracle to determine a crucial action required.
3. Apply escalating pressure: Desynchronization — temporal displacement becomes uncontrollable. Paradox — reality fluctuations create direct danger. Identity — fragmentation intensifies.

If Paradox **10+** (Breach): Faction Intervention occurs (see below).

PHASE 3: RESOLUTION

Make a Crisis Resolution Roll. Choose your approach:

Desynchronization: **2d6 + ENDURE (Difficulty 10)**

Paradox: **2d6 + OBSERVE** or **SYNC (Difficulty 10)**

Identity: **2d6 + ENDURE**, invoking your Locked Memory if you have one

(Difficulty 13)

Add modifiers for relevant Assets (+1 to +2), actions taken during Phase 2 (+1 per successful scene), and desperate sacrifices (burning Coherence, marking Asset Stress).

FOR DESYNCHRONIZATION AND PARADOX CRISES:

12+ Full stabilization. Crisis ends. Restore some resources.

10-11	Partial stabilization. Crisis ends but leaves a lasting consequence.
7-9 BARELY SURVIVE. CRISIS ENDS BUT YOU SUFFER A MAJOR LOSS	Memory, Asset, or Anchor Strength.

6-7 Crisis consumes you. Choose: Transform (retire Echo, become something else) or Dissolve (game over).

IDENTITY CRISIS RESOLUTION (DIFFICULTY 13)

This roll uses your Locked Memory — if you have one, you must invoke it, adding its +3 bonus. This is the moment you locked it for. If you have no Locked Memory, you face the void without an anchor.

12+ Full Stabilization. You remember who you are. Crisis ends. Anchor Strength restored to 1. Gain Scar: Echo of Self — a permanent reminder of the time you almost stopped existing.

10-11 **PARTIAL STABILIZATION. THE CRISIS ENDS, BUT YOU ARE PERMANENTLY CHANGED.**

7-9

6- Dissolution. The final tether snaps. Your Echo dissolves into the timestream. Write your final Chronicle entry as fragments — not sentences, just images and half-words, fading at the edges. Then close the book.

CHURCH INTERVENTION

Templars arrive attempting capture for ritual use.

Roll **2d6** + DISRUPT or **ENDURE (Difficulty 10)**:

12+ Fight them off. Gain +2 Paradox from the violence. They retreat.

7-9 Escape but wounded. Lose 3 Coherence OR mark all Stress on one Asset.

6- Captured. Quick Resolution: suffer 1 Scar, lose 2 Coherence, reduce Paradox by 3, released. Or play the Vignette (Appendix E: Harmonic Crucifixion).

AUTHORITY INTERVENTION

Reality stutters. You're being trapped in a Clone Loop.

Roll **2d6** + **OBSERVE (Difficulty 10)**:

12+ Notice the pattern immediately. Break the loop before it stabilizes. No cost.

7-9 Trapped for **1d6** iterations. Each iteration, one Active Memory becomes Fading. Then escape.

6- Fully looped. Quick Resolution: lose all Active Memories from the scene (become Fading), reduce Paradox by **1d6**, loop releases you. Or play the Vignette (Appendix E: Loop Containment Protocol).

SCIONFALL INTERVENTION

Herald manifests. Nullwave field expands. Colors drain.

Roll **2d6** + **ENDURE (Difficulty 10)**:

12+ Resist through sheer emotional intensity. Generate +3 Paradox to disrupt Nullwave. Herald withdraws.

7-9 Partially affected. Lose 2 Coherence, one Fading Memory becomes Lost. Herald offers one more time, then leaves.

6- Succumbing. Accept cessation (game ends peacefully), OR spend 3 Coherence + invoke Locked Memory to resist (gain Scar: Hollow Moments), OR play the Vignette (Appendix E: The Nullwave Protocol).

CHRONOCLAST INTERVENTION

Time Bomb detonates. Local reality enters superposition.

Roll **2d6** + **OBSERVE (Difficulty 10)**:

12+ Navigate the chaos expertly. Chronoclast applauds. They give you an unstable Asset of your choice.

7-9 Escape but contaminated. Gain +2 Paradox, suffer -1 Coherence from exposure.

6- Lost in decoherence. Quick Resolution: lose **1d6** Coherence, gain Scar: Probability Sight, Chronoclast loses interest. Or play the Vignette (Appendix E: Decoherence Bloom Survival).

WHEN TWO CRISES COLLIDE

If you trigger both a Desynchronization Crisis (Coherence -6) and a Paradox Crisis (Paradox 10+) at the same moment, you do not resolve them separately. They collapse into a single event.

This is a Compound Crisis. Run the three phases once, but:

Phase 1: Pay both immediate costs — mark 1 Asset Stress AND one Active Memory becomes Fading.

Phase 2: Both Faction escalation tables apply — roll **d4** twice. Two Factions arrive. They are not coordinating.

Phase 3: Difficulty increases to 12 for all resolution rolls. The Locked Memory bonus still applies.

RESULTS ON A COMPOUND CRISIS:

12+ Full stabilization. Both Crises end. Restore 2 Coherence and reduce Paradox by 2.

10-11 One Crisis resolves; the other lingers. Choose which. The lingering one triggers again at the start of your next session.

7-9 Barely survive. Choose two from: lose a Memory, lose an Asset, reduce Anchor Strength by 1, gain a Mutation.

6- Dissolution or Terminal Transformation. No partial options.

A Compound Crisis means the Chronoverse has decided you are not a nuisance. You are a problem.

A point I should have raised earlier. When causality attacks you from more than one direction, such as hitting Breach Paradox and Crisis Coherence, accruing multiple Faction Marks, you will have a difficult time maintaining. The deck is quantitatively stacked against you.

The only way out is to reassess the choices you've deferred. Accept an Offer. Burn your Locked Memory. Take the Holding Action. Allow a Mutation.

Echoes who refuse all options will not be able to roll their way out.

— EC

Nietzsche's eternal return was just a Shattering with good PR. Nietzsche thought saying yes was strength. He never met someone who'd actually had to do the infinite life thing.

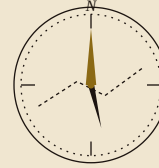
—AR

To the reader who has been wondering.

Alan and I were colleagues. Briefly. We did not part on good terms.

— EC

! Superesse.



CHAPTER VII

Advanced Systems



THE HOLDING ACTION

Once per session, when you would suffer a consequence you cannot afford to bear in this scene, you may declare the Holding Action. The consequence does not vanish. It defers — by exactly one scene, no longer.

The Holding Action is not a tool. It is a refusal. You are telling the timeline that this is not the right moment. The timeline accepts this once. It does not forget you asked. The deferred consequence will arrive, intensified, in the scene that follows. You buy yourself the room to handle it on better ground; you do not avoid handling it.

The Holding Action cannot be repeated until you have completed a Repreival.* *I have used the Holding Action twice in fifteen years. Once it saved someone. Once it cost me the person I used it to save. I will not tell you which was which. — EC

REDUCING PARADOX

STABILIZE REALITY MOVE (2 COHERENCE)

Spend 2 Coherence, then roll **2d6 + SYNC** or **OBSERVE**:

10+ Reduce Paradox by **1d6**.

7-9 Reduce Paradox by **1d3**.

6- **NO REDUCTION**
But you don't generate more.

OTHER METHODS

Accept Memory alterations (let false memories replace true ones): -1

Paradox per major alteration

Work to undo changes you caused

Spend time in an era without interference during Downtime

Accept Faction offers from Church or Authority

ANCHOR REINFORCEMENT

REINFORCE ANCHOR MOVE (2 COHERENCE + ROLL)

Spend 2 Coherence and spend time connecting to your origin — meditation, ritual, reading your Chronicle aloud. Roll **2d6 + ENDURE** (**Difficulty 10**):

12+ **ANCHOR STRENGTH INCREASES BY 1 (MAX 5)**
Gain +2 Coherence.

10-11 Anchor Strength increases by 1 (max 5).

7-9 Anchor stabilizes but doesn't increase.

6- **THE MEMORY WAS A LIE**
Decrease Anchor Strength by 1.

*Why two different stats? Downtime maintenance uses **SYNC** because you are reconnecting emotionally — revisiting the people and places that anchor your waveform. The standalone Reinforce move uses **ENDURE** because you are rebuilding the connection rather than visiting it. One is memory. The other is labor. The distinction matters in the same way the distinction between reading about a country and walking through it matters.*

— EC

ANCHOR STRENGTH LOSS TRIGGERS

Outside of the Reinforce Anchor move, your Anchor Strength can decrease when:

An Identity Crisis resolves at **10-11** (Anchor restored to 1, but any Strength above that is gone)

A Faction Agent's Imposed consequence specifically targets your Anchor (this is rare; it will be stated explicitly when it occurs)

You voluntarily sever an Anchor Connection to gain a mechanical benefit — when you burn the last real thing tethering you to your origin for short-term survival, the Anchor notices

You complete The Return and choose Return Changed — your Anchor binds

permanently, but at whatever Strength it was when you arrived

Anchor Strength does not decrease passively. It decreases when you make a choice that costs you your origin. I have watched Echoes give it away in installments small enough that they did not register the transaction until the Anchor was gone.

— EC

ASSET MANAGEMENT

ASSET EVOLUTION

Assets can improve with use (Levels 1-3). To advance an Asset:

The Asset must be referenced in 3 significant Chronicle entries

Spend 3 Coherence

Spend a Downtime move

Provide narrative justification for the growth

Effect: increase the Asset bonus (+1 → +2 → +3), OR gain an additional capability, OR increase Stress capacity (3 → 4 → 5 boxes).

LEVEL REQUIREMENTS

Level 2 requires Anchor Strength **2+**

Level 3 requires Anchor Strength **4+**

ACQUIRING NEW ASSETS

You start with 2 Assets. During a campaign, you may gain additional Asset slots (up to a maximum of 5 total) through significant narrative events — recovering lost Chrono-Tech in the field, forging a bond with an NPC that crystallizes into a Persistent Connection, or unlocking a new Echo Trait after surviving a Crisis.

Mechanical cost: spend 5 Coherence during Downtime and write a Chronicle entry that justifies the acquisition — what happened, what changed, why this Asset now exists in your world. The new Asset begins at Level 1 with 3 Stress boxes.

Alternatively, a Faction Agent may offer a new Asset as part of a trade — usually unstable, usually with a catch, always tempting.

Five Coherence is a lot. That's the point. You want a new toy, pay for it. The Chronoverse doesn't give things away.

—AR

Assets take damage from critical failures when using them, high Paradox effects, direct attacks, environmental hazards, and temporal Crises.

To repair, roll **2d6** + **OBSERVE** (for Chrono-Tech) or **ENDURE** (for Echo Traits):

10+ Clear all Stress. Asset functions perfectly.

7-9

Clear 2 Stress.

6- Clear 1 Stress. Mark +1 Paradox.

Repair requires Downtime and a narrative explanation of the work.

DOWNTIME MOVES REFERENCE

After resolving a major situation or before forced Displacement, choose **1-2**:

Rest & Recover: restore +2 Coherence, clear 1 Stress from all Assets

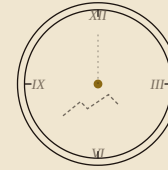
Repair Asset: see Asset Repair rules above

Study Era: immerse in the current time period, create a new Memory related to its culture or technology

Reinforce Anchor: see Anchor Reinforcement above

Reduce Paradox: see Stabilize Reality Move above

! *Ludum longum lude.*



CHAPTER VIII

Long-Term Play



CAMPAIGN STRUCTURES

Temporal Echoes supports several campaign structures. They're not mutually exclusive — your campaign might move between them as circumstances change.

I followed every procedure. Every rule. Every preservation protocol in Chen's manual. I maintained Coherence above +5 for two centuries. I Locked my defining memory. I reinforced my Anchor quarterly. I wrote in the Chronicle every single day.

And this morning I read my first entry. The one I wrote on Day 1, right after Displacement. The one where I described my lab, my daughter, my life.

And I didn't recognize it.

Not that I'd forgotten — the mechanics were intact, the memory was still Active. But reading those words felt like reading someone else's diary. The person who wrote that entry cared about those things. The person reading it now... doesn't.

The Chronicle preserved everything Chen said it would.

It just couldn't preserve the person who cared about preserving it.

I think that might be the joke.

(No signature. No date. The handwriting changes halfway through.)

THE RETURN (10-15 SESSIONS)

Goal: gather knowledge and resources to attempt a return Navigation. Milestones: increase Anchor Strength to 5, reduce Paradox to 0, acquire specific Chrono-Tech Assets, Lock your defining Memory, make the final Navigation roll (Difficulty 13+).

Addendum she didn't write:

End: Success means discovering home doesn't exist anymore. Failure means staying alive long enough to realize you didn't want to go back anyway.

I've met four Echoes who successfully Navigated home. Two dissolved on arrival (temporal rejection). One lasted three days before voluntary Displacement — couldn't stand what their era had become. The fourth is still there, I think. Last I heard they'd been committed for claiming to be a time traveler.

You want to go home? Fine. Here's what you'll find: Everyone you knew is dead or doesn't know you. Your life has been lived by someone else, or never lived at all. The version of you that belonged there is a ghost. And you're the thing haunting it.

Chen will help you try. She's good like that. I'm just telling you what you'll wish you'd known after.

—AR

THE INVESTIGATOR (15-20 SESSIONS)

Goal: understand the nature of Displacement. Milestones: encounter other Echoes, discover Faction operations, piece together the mechanics of time, reach a major revelation about the origin of displacement. End: understanding achieved — but at what cost?

THE WITNESS (OPEN-ENDED)

Goal: document history, preserve what would otherwise be lost. Ongoing play focused on visiting key historical moments, recording events in your Chronicle, meeting historical figures, deciding when and if to intervene. Ends when the Chronicle feels complete, or when memory loss becomes too severe.

THE SURVIVOR (CRISIS-FOCUSED)

EVOLVING THREATS

FACTION ESCALATION

As Paradox rises, Faction interference increases: Shadow (0-3) — unaware of you. Flux (4-6) — Scouts observe. Anomaly (7-9) — Agents intervene. Breach (10+) — active hunting, capture attempts, violence.

TIMELINE INSTABILITY

The more you interfere, the more unstable your surroundings: anachronisms appearing, people remembering multiple versions of events, physical impossibilities manifesting, other Echoes drawn to your disturbance.

PERSONAL DEGRADATION

Track the Scars that accumulate. Note the way your personality shifted. What Anchor Connections are still standing? *Can you still remember why you wanted to go home?*

ENDING YOUR STORY

The game ends when one of the following becomes true. I have no preference among them.

— EC

RETURN ACHIEVED

You finally reach home. Ask yourself: are you the same person who left? Then choose:

Return Intact: you maintain all Memories (even Fading), you return as close to your original self as possible, but you can never leave again — your Anchor binds you permanently. You're home. You're also trapped. And linearity can be painful after displacement.

Return Changed: you accept the Mutations and lost Memories, you return as a transformed version of yourself, the people you left behind don't fully recognize you. You're 'home,' but you're a stranger.

DISSOLUTION

Coherence cannot be restored. Identity too fragmented. Final Chronicle entry: fragments, then silence.

ACCEPTANCE

You choose to stop fighting. You make peace with displacement. You find a new Anchor in an adopted era. Chronicle entry: I was someone else. Now I am this.

TRANSFORMATION

You deliberately let go of your origin. You become something new. You retire your Echo to the timestream. Chronicle entry: I remember who I was. I choose to forget.

Chen wrote this chapter in 2038. I checked.

She still believed The Return was possible then. She had a route mapped out. She had Anchor reinforcement protocols and a list of likely landing eras and a plan for the first month back.

She doesn't write like this anymore.

If you reach Chapter 8 and you can still feel her certainty, hold it carefully. It was real once.

— AR

INTERLUDE

Playing Both

A NOTE FROM THE JOURNALIST

So. You finished Chen's book. Or you skipped to here, which is allowed, but you should know that some of what follows won't make sense without the first half.

I read them in order. Chen first. That seemed safer at the time. I was wrong about the safety. I was right about the order. Alan's book makes more sense once you already know what he's arguing with.

What's below is what the two manuscripts agreed on. Which isn't much.

If you're carrying an Echo from Chen's game into Alan's, this is the trade. What you fought hardest to keep in Book One becomes the thing Book Two is going to take from you. I don't know if they planned it that way. I don't think they were on speaking terms when these sections were written. But you can feel them arguing across the gap, and the argument has a shape, and the shape is below.

The rules are short. The cost is not.

Caveat lector. Again.

YOUR LOCKED MEMORY BECOMES YOUR CORE SCAR.

The bonus transfers intact. What you fought hardest to preserve becomes your most dangerous weapon.

YOUR HIGHEST REMAINING ANCHOR CONNECTION BECOMES A PERSISTENT CONNECTION ASSET AT LEVEL 1.

The person or place you held onto longest is now something you can deploy.

YOU BEGIN WITH ONE ADDITIONAL MUTATION: REMEMBERS WHEN PRESERVATION MATTERED.

Once per campaign, you may perform a Holding Action without it counting toward the once-per-campaign limit. You know what you traded. Sometimes that knowledge surfaces.

YOUR FINAL ANCHOR STRENGTH DETERMINES YOUR STARTING CORRUPTION VECTOR.

Subtract your Echo's final Anchor Strength (1-5) from 5. The result is your starting Corruption Vector (0-4).

An Echo who fought tooth and nail to preserve themselves (Anchor Strength 5) begins emiT almost fully human — Corruption Vector 0. They have the furthest to fall. An Echo whose Anchor was already shattered (Anchor Strength 1) begins already deep in the transformation — Corruption Vector 4. They are lighter, and more dangerous, and there is less of them left to lose.

This is the tragedy the two books share. Everything you fought to preserve in Chen's game becomes the measure of what you stand to lose in Alan's.

A NOTE ON ANCHOR 0

If your Echo's Anchor Strength reached 0 — if you dissolved, if the Identity Crisis took everything — you begin emiT at Corruption Vector 5. Not because you won. Because there's nothing left to lose. You arrive at Alan's book with the ceiling intact and the floor already gone. That's its own kind of tragedy.

Chen built a boat. Alan learned to breathe water.

Both books are correct. Neither is sufficient.

If you have read this far, you are in the gap between the two answers. The gap is where the third thing lives – the thing neither of them will name, because naming it would require admitting the choice was never between preservation and transformation. The choice was between two ways of refusing to disappear.

You are about to enter the second book. The book of the one who chose to disappear into something useful.

emiT

A Solo Journaling RPG About What You Become When
Preservation Stops Being the Point

By Alan Rose

`[SYSTEM BOOT]... CORRUPTED`

`[LOADING DIRECTIVE]... FAILED`

`[WARNING: NON-LINEAR NARRATIVE HAZARD] You
are not the first version of yourself to read this.`

You want to know how I learned this. 2044. Four of us in a building that was already coming down. I had ninety seconds to decide which one of the other three I was going to –

Never mind.

Transformation has timing. Wait until you're ready and you've already waited too long.

// AR

The signal does not decay. It is the receiver that rots. To hear the sweet siren song of the Chronoverse is to invite the frequency to dismantle you. This manual is the infection. Begin.

Time is not an ocean or a river. It's a broken machine. You don't 'drift' – you short-circuit between eras. The currents are live wires. The depths are full of things that used to be people.

This is a survival manual for the temporally contaminated. You've been Displaced. Your memory is degrading. Reality is hostile. Your goal is to last long enough to become dangerous.

I've been doing this for 340 years. Here's what I've learned: identity is expensive. Transformation is cheap.

You can spend decades clinging to who you were, burning resources like rocket fuel, white-knuckling every Memory until your mind breaks. Or you can adapt. Let the parts that don't work anymore fall away. Keep what's useful. Become something that can survive what would have killed who you were.

The universe is trying to kill you. Your Memories are weapons. Your Scars are ammunition. Use them.

Dr. Eleanor Chen // [DATE UNKNOWN]

Alan, what's your goal? Echoes need our help. Stop turning them into weapons.

THE WRECK: WHAT YOU ARE

You're a Wreck. Something that broke but kept moving. I've stopped using the words *traveler* and *victim* because both of them imply you were doing something to time. You weren't. Time was doing something to you, and you survived it.

All Wrecks share three things.

1. OPERATIONAL

You've stopped letting displacement happen to you. You use it. Navigate it. Deploy it strategically.

2. CORRUPTED

Your original configuration is gone. What remains is scar tissue, adaptation, whatever worked. You're more effective than you were. More functional.

3. DANGEROUS

You generate instability. Reality rejects you. Factions hunt you. You've learned to weaponize all of it.

There's a moment every Wreck hits – usually around year 50, sometimes earlier. You wake up in some era and realize you don't remember why you're trying to preserve your original identity. The person you were is a stranger. Their goals don't make sense anymore.

You have two choices: spend the next century trying to rebuild that stranger, or ask what this version of you can do that the old one couldn't.

I chose option two. Still here. Still moving.

THE REAL SITUATION

By now you've noticed. Every time you hold onto who you were, it costs more than it should. Your Coherence burns. Your Anchor gets heavier.

Let one of those pieces go and you'll feel the change in the next jump. Less to lose if something hits you.

Tragedy or tactical advantage. Depends what you're after.

Dr. Eleanor Chen // [DATE UNKNOWN]

Alan, this is Dr. Eleanor Chen. I'm accessing your manuscript remotely – Zaaken gave me the frequency.

I need you to understand what you're teaching them. This 'operational efficiency' you're advocating? It's dissociation. The 'tactical advantage of emotional detachment'? That's trauma response, not evolution.

You're not describing transcendence. You're describing survival mechanisms that will leave them hollow.

I know you think I'm naive. I know 340 years has taught you things I haven't learned in 30. But please – warn them what they're trading.

CONTENT WARNING

This game treats identity dissolution as evolution, memory loss as optimization, trauma as tactical resource. If the static gets too loud, close the book. The words will wait.

Mars colony, 3047. The year before the collapse. I was there.

People don't write about Mars before the collapse, mostly because the people who lived there knew what was coming and the people who didn't, didn't ask. The dome leaked. Everyone could taste the

Stop pretending you're still human. You are a walking weapon. A living bomb on causality and a bona fide wound in space-time. Own it.

When Paradox climbs, your Modes shift.

You lose **SYNC** because **SYNC** was the part of you that needed other people to validate that you were real. You don't need that anymore, and can't afford it. Every Coherence point you spend trying to feel like a person is one less point you have when the timeline shows up to collect its debt.

You gain **DISRUPT** because subtlety gets you killed. The first hundred Echoes who tried to be clever are rotting corpses buried somewhere in time. The ones still kicking did so by being blunt instruments at the right moment.

Read the equations and stop arguing with them.

ARCHITECTURE OF A WRECK

You begin with an origin (subject to revision), damage (mandatory), and a trajectory (inevitable).

WHAT THEY CALLED YOU

Write these in pencil. By session 10, you'll have different answers than you started with. By session 20, you'll realize the origin story was always negotiable – a narrative you construct to explain your current behavior. That's fine. Use the fiction. We're all just drafts.

Name: What they called you

Origin Era: When and where you're from

Displacement Event: What unmoored you

HOW FAR GONE YOU ARE

Track your transformation direction on a scale of 5 to 0. You start at 5 – still recognizably human. Each time it decreases, you shed one connection to your origin, gain one operational capability, and become harder to dissolve and easier to misunderstand.

At 0: Final Transformation (see Chapter 6).

Your Corruption Vector decreases by 1 when you: choose 'Embrace Corruption' during Crisis resolution, gain your third Mutation in a single session, or voluntarily accept a Faction transformation offer. Nothing else decreases it. It only moves in one direction. This isn't death. This is becoming something else.

WHICH WAY YOU'RE FALLING

Your trajectory shapes how you play from the first session. Choose one and write it on your Corruption Log. Each trajectory unlocks one move immediately.

TRAJECTORY IMMEDIATE MOVE

Weaponized Once per session, when you generate Paradox through a roll, you may immediately convert it into a +1 bonus on your next **DISRUPT** roll. The contradiction becomes ammunition.

Hollowed When a Scar becomes Lost, you may choose not to gain a Mutation. Instead, describe what you no longer feel. Write it in your Log. No mechanical consequence. Just the record.

Fragmented When you fail a roll, you may ask: What would another version of me have done? Answer the question in your Log, then roll again using that framing. The second result stands, whether better or worse.

Infectious When you interact with an NPC, you may choose to transfer 1 point of your Paradox to them. Reduce your Paradox by 1. They become slightly wrong afterward – describe how. The NPC now carries a piece of your contamination.

Transcendent Once per session, you may describe what you perceive that others cannot – branching timelines, the echo of futures that won't happen, the weight of causality in a room. This perception is accurate. Gain +2 to your next roll. But you must also describe one thing you can no longer perceive normally. Write it in your Log. Accumulate these losses.

HOW YOU FUNCTION NOW

You have four instinctual approaches: **OBSERVE** (analysis, threat detection, pattern recognition), **SYNC** (connection, manipulation, adaptation), **ENDURE** (damage absorption, persistence), **DISRUPT** (force, violence, causality breaking).

But here's what other displacement manuals don't tell you: these numbers aren't fixed. As temporal contamination increases, your operational profile shifts.

PARADOX LEVEL MODE RATINGS

Shadow (0-3) **OBSERVE** +2 / **SYNC** +1 / **ENDURE** +0 / **DISRUPT** -1
 Flux (4-6) **OBSERVE** +1 / **SYNC** +0 / **ENDURE** +1 / **DISRUPT** +1
 Anomaly (7-9) **OBSERVE** +0 / **SYNC** -1 / **ENDURE** +2 / **DISRUPT** +2
 Breach (10+) **OBSERVE** -1 / **SYNC** -2 / **ENDURE** +3 / **DISRUPT** +3

The more contaminated you become, the less you can analyze or connect. The more you can endure and destroy. You will become a blunt instrument whether you choose to or not. This is the core mechanic. Corruption changes who you are at the

Dr. Eleanor Chen // [DATE UNKNOWN]

This is what I was afraid of.

The stat shifts you're describing? That's not evolution. That's loss of analytical capacity (**OBSERVE** drops), social disconnection (**SYNC** drops), emotional numbing (**ENDURE** rises), violence as primary response (**DISRUPT** rises).

You're gamifying PTSD symptoms.

I understand why you frame it as adaptation. I understand 340 years has required you to function this way. But please – for once – admit what it cost you.

WHAT HURTS

You begin with 5 Scars – formative wounds that shaped your operational capacity. Unlike Chen's Memories, you're not trying to preserve these. You reload them.

For each Scar, write:

Name – brief, evocative

Context Tags – when it applies

Invocation – what you can do with it and the bonus

EXAMPLE SCAR:

BERLIN, 1989

TAGS: COLLAPSE / BORDERS / IMPOSSIBLE ESCAPE

Invocation: +2 to **DISRUPT** when breaking containment

WHAT'S LEFT

Choose 2 Assets from any category. All start Level 1 with 3 Stress boxes. See Appendix B for full catalog. Asset Corruption: every time you Push a Chrono-Tech Asset, roll **d6**. On **1-2**, it

ASSET STATES (EMIT)

Every Asset in emit exists in one of three states. Track this on your sheet.

Clean – The Asset functions as written. No additional effects.

Compromised – The Asset has taken at least 1 Stress from a Glitch (the **1-2** result on the **d6** roll). While Compromised, its passive bonus drops by 1 (a +2 **OBSERVE** becomes +1 **OBSERVE**). It still functions. It just costs more to maintain than it gives back. This is what most tools become eventually.

Weaponized – You have deliberately pushed a Glitched Asset past its limit, accepting the contamination as the point. A Weaponized Asset has all Stress boxes marked, grants no passive bonus, and cannot be repaired. But once per session, you may invoke it for a +3 bonus to any roll that fits its fiction – you're not using the tool, you're using what the tool's failure has taught you. After invoking a Weaponized Asset, roll **d6**. On **1-2**, it breaks permanently. Remove it from your sheet. Do not write a replacement yet. Sit with the gap.

Assets move from Clean →Compromised when Glitch Stress accumulates. Compromised →Weaponized is a choice, not a threshold – you decide when something broken is more useful broken than repaired.

TRAJECTORY MOVES

Being a wreck means you never stop moving. The Moves below are the six ways you direct that motion.

¹⁰⁷
1. Lean Into It. When you take damage, push it forward instead of resisting. Spend 1 Coherence;

2. Cut the Cord. When an Anchor Connection is becoming a liability, deliberately sever it. Mark it as severed in your Chronicle. -2 Coherence immediately, but the Connection no longer triggers Memory Fading on relevant rolls.

3. Burn a Memory. When you need a +3 you can't otherwise reach, spend an Active Memory. The Memory is gone – not Faded, gone. Erased from the slot. This is the one I told her not to put in the book. She made me put it in anyway. – EC

4. Resonance Welding. When something near you is destroyed and you're already Compromised, you can absorb a fragment of it as a temporary Asset. The Asset lasts until the end of the session and then disappears, leaving a Mutation behind.

5. The Holding Action. Once per session, when you would suffer a consequence you cannot afford, declare The Holding Action. The consequence is delayed by exactly one scene. The Holding Action cannot be repeated until you have completed a Repeival.

6. Trajectory Lock. When you make a decision you cannot undo, write it down and circle it. From this point forward, you cannot take any action that contradicts the locked decision. The lock is permanent until released by a Crisis. This is the move Chen would not let me put in her book. It's why we have two books. – AR

Memory is not storage. Memory is structure. When the structure fails, the building does not empty – it collapses. In the rubble, we find weapons.

Resolution (The Collapse Protocol)

When outcomes are uncertain, roll 2d6 + Mode + Scar Bonus (if applicable).

12+ Complete Success. Achieve goal cleanly. Reality bends. Gain +1 Coherence.

7-9 Success with Complication. Achieve goal but the Oracle introduces cost, twist, or new danger.

6- Failure with Discovery. Goal fails, but you learn something useful. Choose: lose 1 Coherence OR mark +1 Paradox.

Navigation (Controlled Displacement)

Jumping is usually something that happens to you – but you can attempt Precision Navigation.

Roll 2d6 + **OBSERVE** + Scar Bonus (if applicable). Every Navigation attempt costs 1 Coherence, paid before rolling. Involuntary jumps don't cost Coherence – they just happen to you.

TARGET DIFFICULTY EXAMPLE

Difficulty 7: Nearby (±0 years) or a 1890s London, again

place you've been before

Difficulty 10: Distant (±00-500 years) Ming Dynasty China

or unfamiliar location

Difficulty 12: Extreme (±000+ years) The exact hour of the First Scar

or a specific moment

12+ Perfect Landing. Arrive exactly when and where intended. No complications. Gain +1 Coherence.

111 10-11 Successful Navigation. Arrive at intended destination. Mark +1 Paradox from the effort.

Your synchronization with the current timestream. Tracks from -6 to your maximum. Your maximum Wave Coherence = Corruption Vector + 3. At Vector 5 (fully human) your ceiling is 8, same as Chen's starting max. At Vector 0 (fully corrupted) your ceiling is 3. The further you transform, the less coherence you can hold. That's not a bug.

// AR

Chen gets a comfortable Flux band to drift in. You don't. You've got three points between functioning and collapse. Use them carefully, or use them all at once – but know what you're spending.

// AR

STATE EFFECT

Synchronized (+4 to +8) +1 to all rolls

Flux (0 to +3) No modifier

Crisis (-6 to -1) -1 to all rolls. At -6: trigger Fracture Event.

PARADOX (TEMPORAL CONTAMINATION)

Track from 0 to **10+**. Generate Paradox when you alter recorded history significantly (+1 to +3), share anachronistic knowledge (+1), create causal loops (+2), or use glitching Chrono-Tech (+1).

HIGH PARADOX ISN'T JUST DANGER

Look at those Mode shifts again. At Paradox 7-9, your **DISRUPT** is +2, your **ENDURE** is +2. You're being hunted. You're also powerful. At Paradox 10+, your **DISRUPT** is +3, your **ENDURE** is +3. You've become priority target and extremely difficult to kill.

// AR

MEMORY SYSTEM

Five Active Scars (+2 bonus), three Fading Scars (+1 bonus), one Core Scar (+3 bonus – costs 3 Coherence to lock). When you experience something significant, create a new Scar and push everything forward.

When a Scar becomes Lost: gain a Mutation (permanent personality change). Choose from phantom reflex, emotional void, sensory glitch, or behavioral rewire.

In emiT, when a Scar is Lost, it becomes a Mutation. The identity wound externalizes into temporal corruption. This is the conversion rate of selfhood into survival.

// AR

WEAPONIZING SCARS

You can spend Scars offensively. Invoke a Scar for its bonus, then burn it to: deal direct damage to a situation, NPC, or timeline; force reality to accept a contradiction; or make someone forget something specific. Cost: Scar becomes Lost immediately, gain a Mutation.

Call it tactical expenditure of identity. Call it self-destruction. Both lines lead to the same spreadsheet. Spend accordingly.

// AR

Dr. Eleanor Chen // [DATE UNKNOWN]

Alan, stop.

You're teaching them to weaponize their trauma and frame permanent psychological damage as Mutations.

This isn't strength. This is dissociative coping that will leave them unable to connect with anyone, unable to feel normally, unable to recognize themselves.

Buzz off, doc. It's not like you remember what happened. Otherwise you'd be on my side. You were once.

Remember the First Scar? The night in '44 when the four of us –

Never mind.

// AR

[CHEN]: Four?**THE CORRUPTION LOG**

Document your transformation in your journal. Track: current Paradox state, Corruption Vector progress, Scars acquired and spent, Mutations gained, what you took from each era.

Creating a detailed entry grants +1 Paradox – not Coherence. You grow stronger by documenting corruption, not by clinging to your origin.

THE VIOLENCE TAX

Violence is taxed. The tax is paid in pieces of you that you don't get back.

Ten violent acts. The tracker fills as you act. At the end of every Repeival, the tracker resets – but only after you pay. The payment options are: a Mutation, the loss of a Scar that was useful to you, or being witnessed by someone whose memory of you was clean.

I have hit the tracker reset eleven times. I no longer remember which payments I chose for the first six. I remember the witnessed ones. I remember the faces of the people who saw me do what I did. They are the ones still in my head, even after the rest of the violence has filed itself away into something that feels almost neutral.

The tax is not a punishment. It is the cost of doing this. The illusion is that there will be a moment of cleanness – a reset where the blood is

When you succeed with **DISRUPT** (any result), roll **d6**. On **3-6**: no tax this time. On **1-2**: pay the Tax.

PAYING THE TAX

Choose ONE option you have NOT chosen since your last Repeival. If all options have been chosen since last Repeival, you must take a Mutation.

Mutation – gain a permanent personality change immediately

Scar Loss – one Active Scar becomes Lost immediately (gain Mutation

from the loss)

Witnessed – mark WITNESSED; your next social interaction this era

takes -1 **SYNC** and the Oracle introduces someone responding to what they

saw you become

VIOLENCE ESCALATION

Track **VIOLENCE COUNT** (starts at **0** each session). Each time you trigger the Violence Tax, increase the count by **1**. When you take **Repeival**, reset Violence Count to **0**.

The count is narrative pressure. By the fourth or fifth Tax of a session, the consequences stop being mechanical and start being who you are becoming. Write it down. Let it accumulate.

// AR

I didn't have this rule for my first 200 years. I just used DISRUPT whenever I needed to end something. Every problem became a nail because I'd become a hammer.

If I'd been tracking Violence Count honestly? I'd be at four digits.

The Tax isn't punishment. It's just making visible what was always happening.

Every time you solve something through violence, you lose a piece. Eventually you realize you've got nothing left but the violence.

That's not evolution. That's addiction.

– AR (two hundred years later)

The Holding Action

Once per session, when doing so is meaningfully costly, you may choose preservation over optimization. You cannot perform a Holding Action in a scene of safety or momentum. Preservation only matters when it costs you something.

Describe an act of human preservation:

- Comfort someone who can't help you*
- Honor a promise when breaking it would be easier*
- Maintain a ritual that serves no tactical purpose*
- Write someone's name when they're already gone*
- Apologize when it won't change the outcome*

Roll 2d6 + SYNC or OBSERVE (your choice).

10+ Choose one: Reduce Paradox by 1, OR restore 1 Coherence.

7-9 No mechanical benefit. Narrate why it mattered anyway. Sometimes meaning is enough.

6- The universe doesn't care about sentimentality. Mark +1 Paradox.

// AR

I never took Holding Actions for the first 200 years. Not because I didn't want to. Because I convinced myself they didn't work.

Every time I considered one, I'd think: this costs resources. What's the return? Where's the tactical advantage?

And I'd choose Violence Tax instead. Because Violence Tax works.

But here's what I didn't calculate: Violence Tax works and empties you.

Holding Actions often don't work mechanically. But they're the only thing that reminds you why survival mattered in the first place.

By the time I figured that out, I'd forgotten what I was trying to preserve.

Maybe if I'd failed more Holding Actions, I'd still know.

// AR

Dr. Eleanor Chen // [DATE UNKNOWN]

Alan tried a Holding Action in session 847.

He was in 1920s Berlin. Met a woman who reminded him of Sarah. Spent an entire scene teaching her to play chess because Sarah used to play chess.

He rolled **7-9**. No mechanical benefit.

He wrote in his Log: 'Wasted scene. Should have Navigated instead.'

Three sessions later, he couldn't remember Sarah's face.

The Holding Action wasn't wasted. It was the last time he connected with anything real. The **7-9** didn't give Coherence. It gave meaning. He just couldn't see the difference anymore.

I should say something about Chen before we go further.

REPREIVAL

Not a reprieve. A reprieve implies you're forgiven, or that you've earned a rest. This is a Repreival - a temporary stay of execution. You're still being hunted. The timeline still wants you normalized. You're just getting a few hours where nothing is actively trying to end you. Use them.

// AR

WHEN TO TAKE REPREIVAL

After every **Navigation** roll or **Displacement**, OR at the end of your real-world play session if neither occurred.

REPREIVAL RITUAL (IN ORDER)

1. Chronicle. Write in your Log: where and when you are, what happened, one significant choice you made, one thing you lost or changed. Don't pretty it up. If you write enough, you might trick your brain into thinking you're real. Effect: gain **+1 Coherence**.

2. Fix the Anchor. If your **Anchor** took Stress, roll **2d6 + SYNC** (Difficulty **10**).

- > **10+:** clear all Anchor Stress. Good as new.
- > **7-9:** clear 1 Stress. You patched one hole.
- > **6-:** no Stress cleared. It's still junk.

3. Scavenge Assets. For each Stressed Asset, roll **2d6 + relevant Mode**.

- > **10+**: clear all Stress. Working again.
- > **7-9**: clear 1 Stress. Working mostly.
- > **6-**: still trash. If an Asset is fully broken, spend the whole Repreival fixing it or find a replacement.

4. Let It Rot. Your oldest Active **Scar** fades. Your oldest Fading Scar vanishes and leaves a **Mutation** behind. Your **Core Scar** never fades. Create new Scars for significant events. You can't stop the rot. You can only watch it.

5. Cool Down (Optional). Try to lower your **Paradox**, or don't.

- > **Temporal Grounding:** Roll **2d6 + SYNC** (Difficulty **10**). On **10+**: reduce Paradox by **2**. On **7-9**: reduce by **1**.
- > **Ritual Purification:** Reduce Paradox by **1d6**. The cost depends on method, and a Faction's "cleaning" costs you a piece of your soul.
- > **Run hot.** See what happens.

6. Next Target. Answer in your Log: *What am I trying to break next?* Write it down. If you don't have a target, you're just waiting to die.

7. Reset Violence Count to 0.

The factions think they can use you. Other way around. You use THEM.

The Church of the Holy Second: pain-loving pious torturers who correctly believe that suffering stabilizes reality. The Loop Authority: punchclock middle management, ruthlessly efficient, motto being that recursion eliminates deviation. The Scionfall Directive: killers disguising themselves with kindness. The Chronoclasts: my kind of people, once. A bit too extreme for my tastes these days.

// AR

FACTION ATTENTION

Tied to Paradox. Shadow (0-3): invisible to them.

Flux (4-6): Scouts observe when you roll 6-.

Anomaly (7-9): Agents intervene when you roll **7-9**, they make Offers. Breach (10+): direct intervention during Fracture Event Phase 2.

Agent Offers

When an Agent appears, choose: Accept (pay the cost, gain the benefit), Refuse (they Impose consequence and Mark you), or Drive Off (roll DISRUPT to force them away, **Difficulty 10**).

Offers are your non-roll path to Paradox relief. Sell pieces of yourself to regain control.

AGENT OFFER / COST

Church Templar Offer: Take 1 Mutation + lose 2 Coherence →Reduce Paradox by 3 Refused: Lose 1 Coherence. Marked – next encounter automatic.

Authority Corrector Offer: Normalize 1 Scar (bonus drops to +0) →Reduce Paradox by 2, clear Asset Stress Refused: -1 to Navigation until Repreival. Marked. Scionfall Herald Offer:

Character retired. Game ends peacefully. Refused: -1 **ENDURE** while present. Marked – returns during

PATTERN RECOGNITION (PARADOX 7+)

Sometimes the contamination rises faster than your analytical capacity drops. The gap is small and short, but while it lasts, you can see the next move before the timeline commits to it. Most Echoes do not survive long enough to develop it.

// AR

Available when: **Paradox 7+** and **OBSERVE ≥+1**.

Once per session, declare: I see what's coming. State a specific complication (who/what, where, what it threatens). Mark 1 Coherence immediately. Mark the complication as BOUND. The Oracle must introduce it within the next 3 scenes, and when it arrives, you gain +2 to one roll taken in response.

If you reach Repreival before it appears, it still arrives anyway – upgraded one severity level – and you gain +1 Mutation from the strain of sustained prophetic perception.

I've met two Echoes with maintained high-Paradox OBSERVE.

First one: stopped speaking in linear sentences. Everything was will happen / happened / happening. Grammatical tenses collapsed. Couldn't interact with anyone.

Second one: accurate predictions, perfect positioning. Survived 18 Crisis events through foreknowledge. Then predicted her own dissolution. Saw it coming for three weeks. Couldn't prevent it. Just watched it approach.

She chose Scionfall on day 17. Said waiting was worse than the end.

Prophecy doesn't make you safe. It makes you witness your own failure in advance.

Chen thinks of these guys as panic attacks because she still believes you can survive them through technique.

I call them what they are. A Crisis is something that happens to you. A Fracture is something you become.

Fractures have three sounds. First: a high whine you mistake for the building. Then: the silence after the whine, which is the silence of a system finishing a calculation. Then: the calculation's output, which is the new shape of you.

Three Fractures live in this chapter. Each has its own physics. All three sound the same in the first thirty seconds.

// AR

The first Fracture Event isn't the worst one.

The worst one is the one that made the category exist. The one that made someone sit down and say, we need a word for this. We need a formal mechanical framework for the thing that happens when four people are in a room together and at the end of it there are only three categories of person left in the world.

You don't need the details. You'll Fracture in your own way.

// AR

Fractures occur when your current configuration becomes untenable. Three triggers: **Coherence -6** (Desynchronization), **Paradox 10+** (Breach), **Corruption Vector 0** (Final Transformation).

THREE-PHASE RESOLUTION

PHASE 1: MANIFESTATION

Roll on the appropriate Oracle. Pay the immediate cost: lose 1 Coherence, one Scar becomes Fading, mark 1 Asset Stress.

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PHASE 2: ESCALATION

CHURCH INTERVENTION (emiT) Templars arrive. They want your Scars – the weaponized trauma you've been accumulating is holy to them. Roll **2d6** + **DISRUPT** or **ENDURE (Difficulty 10)**.

10+ FIGHT THEM OFF

Gain +2 Paradox from the violence. Gain +1 Corruption Vector decrease from the exposure to their harvesting field.

7-9 ESCAPE DAMAGED

They strip one of your Active Scars as a tithe. Lose its bonus permanently. They leave satisfied.

6- TAKEN

Quick Resolution: lose 2 Coherence, one Scar is harvested (bonus gone, becomes Lost, gain Mutation), Paradox reduced by 3. You're released. Or play Appendix E: Harmonic Crucifixion.

AUTHORITY INTERVENTION (emiT) Clone Loop. They're trying to normalize you back into the baseline – but you've Mutated past easy correction. The loop can't quite contain you anymore. Roll **2d6** + **OBSERVE (Difficulty 10)**.

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10+ SLIP THE PATTERN

You recognize the recursion before it sets. No cost. The Authority marks you as a Loop-Resistant anomaly –they'll escalate next time.

7-9 PARTIALLY LOOPED

Two iterations. Each one costs 1 Active Scar (becomes Fading). Then the loop dissolves –your Mutations create too much instability to hold.

6- FULL LOOP

Quick Resolution: all Active Scars become Fading, Paradox reduced by **1d6**. They release you –processing you was more destabilizing than containing you. Or play Appendix E: Loop Containment Protocol.

SCIONFALL INTERVENTION (emiT) A Herald manifests. The Nullwave field expands. For a Wreck at your stage, the offer isn't cessation – it's integration. Absorption into the Scionfall archive as a preserved configuration. Roll **2d6 + ENDURE (Difficulty 10)**.

10+ RESIST

The warmth recedes. Paradox reduced by 1 (the Nullwave bled some off). They note your resistance. They'll send a Herald with better numbers next time.

7-9 PARTIAL ABSORPTION

One Scar is integrated –archived by Scionfall, no longer yours. You feel its absence as a specific kind of silence. Paradox reduced by 2.

6- OFFER ACCEPTED OR FORCED

CHRONOCLAST INTERVENTION (emiT) They don't intervene. They appear and watch. A Wreck at high Paradox is interesting to them – the contamination patterns, the Mutation cascade, the aesthetic of a person becoming something unprecedented. Roll **2d6 + SYNC (Difficulty 8)**.

10+ THEY'RE IMPRESSED

They offer a gift: choose one –reduce Paradox by 3, clear all Asset Stress, or gain a new Mutation of your choice. They leave humming.

7-9 THEY COLLABORATE

They make one change to your current situation –something chaotic, something that makes things worse and more interesting simultaneously. You didn't ask for this. Gain +1 Paradox, gain +1 to your next roll.

6- YOU'RE THE ART NOW

They add you to something. What, you don't know. Your next Paradox generation roll produces double the normal amount. This lasts until Reprise.

PHASE 3: RESOLUTION

Standard Resolution: Roll **2d6 + ENDURE (Difficulty 10)**.

12+ STABILIZE COMPLETELY

Restore some resources.

10-11 STABILIZE WITH CONSEQUENCES

Fracture ends.

7-9 BARELY SURVIVE

Major loss –Scar, Asset, or Corruption
Vector decrease.

6- CONFIGURATION FAILS

Choose: Transform or Dissolve.

ALTERNATIVE: EMBRACE CORRUPTION

Roll **2d6 + DISRUPT** (Difficulty **8**) instead. Lower difficulty, but automatic consequences:

Corruption Vector decreases by 1, gain a **Mutation**, mark **+3 Paradox**, gain a new operational **Capability**.

*Crisis as transformation opportunity. Easier door.
Higher exit cost.*

// AR

The four configurations below are end-states. They are not character classes. They are eulogies that the system has not yet finished writing.

THE VESSEL. *The Vessel is the end-state of an Echo who has spent everything they had on staying useful. The Vessel still walks, still solves problems, still completes objectives at a rate that exceeds most Echoes who are fully present. What is missing is the part of them that would have been able to say why any of it mattered. Vessels are functional. They are not haunted, because there is nothing left to haunt.*

THE PARADOX ENGINE. *The Paradox Engine is what happens when an Echo accepts the contradiction instead of resolving it. The Engine generates new paradoxes faster than the timeline can absorb them. They are extraordinarily powerful, but there's a price of course. Other Echoes who spend time near the Engine find their own coherence eroding. The Engine destabilizes everything and anyone in proximity, so survival is guaranteed, but connection is impossible.*

THE HOLLOWED. *The Hollowed is the Echo who chose Scionfall's mercy and survived it anyway. Hollowed have memory and consciousness intact, but no will to use either. Hollows are present, but that's about it. A Hollow will consent to whatever is asked of them. Hollows are at peace, but in the way that corpses are at peace.*

THE DISSOLVED. *The Dissolved is the Revel's favorite. Dissolved exist in superposition across multiple timeline branches, none of them the dominant strand. They are technically free. They are also not coherent enough to enjoy the freedom. When you encounter a Dissolved, you encounter four or five of them at once, each one an expression of who the Echo would have been on*

When Corruption Vector reaches 0, you stop being human. What you become depends on your trajectory.

These are not transcendence states. They are what survival looks like when you've optimized for nothing else. Are they victories? Tragedies? That depends on what you think survival is worth.

FINAL TRANSFORMATIONS

WEAPONIZED →THE PARADOX ENGINE You've become walking instability. Immune to contamination because you are contamination. Mechanics: immune to Paradox effects, can spend 2 Coherence to generate +1 Paradox in a target, Faction Agents flee on sight. Cost: everyone flees on sight. You're functionally alone.

HOLLOWED →THE VESSEL Perfect adaptability through complete amnesia. You can be anyone because you're no one. Mechanics: inhabit any era without Coherence cost, adopt any identity instantly (perfect **SYNC** disguise), no Scars can fade. Cost: you don't remember why any identity matters. Including your own.

FRAGMENTED →THE SWARM You exist in multiple timelines simultaneously. Mechanics: exist in **1d6** timelines simultaneously, roll twice on any roll and choose the best result, sacrifice one fragment to auto-succeed (that version dies, you continue). Cost: which one is really you? They're diverging. Eventually they'll have different goals. You'll be your own enemy.

RECURSIVE →THE OUROBOROS You've become a closed causal loop. Mechanics: communicate with past/future versions during Crisis, summon past-you as an ally once per session (with your stats from 5 sessions ago). Cost: you're trapped in

INFECTIOUS →THE CARRIER You spread instability to everyone you touch. Mechanics: any NPC you interact with gains +1 Paradox, spend 3 Coherence to force Displacement on a target, Faction Agents prioritize you above all others. Cost: everyone you care about becomes contaminated. You're contagion. You're alone.

TRANSCENDENT →THE OBSERVER Four-dimensional consciousness. Mechanics: immune to Faction intervention (they can't perceive you correctly), rewrite one roll per session to any result, Navigate at will without rolling. Cost: you can't meaningfully interact with three-dimensional beings anymore. You're a ghost watching through glass.

THE EXIT QUESTION

Before you stabilize into your Terminal Configuration, answer one question in writing:

What was the last thing you cared about that wasn't useful?

A person. A place. A value. A ritual. Something you did because it mattered, not because it worked. Write it in your Log. Then choose one:

PRESERVE IT

It becomes your Final Anchor. You may end the game with one scene where you protect, honor, or return to it. Cost: you Dissolve immediately afterward. The preservation costs your existence. This is one ending – meaning preserved, self sacrificed.

DELETE IT

You stabilize into your Terminal Configuration completely. Cost: you can never again take **SYNC** actions that aren't manipulative. All connection

There is no third option. You choose which you keep: the meaning or the self. Not both.

I reached Corruption Vector 0 in 2287.

The Exit Question came. I wrote: Sarah's laugh. The way she sounded when something was genuinely funny – not polite-funny.

I chose Delete.

I don't remember what her laugh sounded like anymore. I remember that I should remember. I remember it mattered.

But the sound itself? Gone. The feeling of why it mattered? Gone.

I'm still here. Still operational. Still moving.

I don't know if that counts for something.

But I'm still broadcasting.

// AR

Dr. Eleanor Chen // [DATE UNKNOWN]

Alan.

You wrote that in 2287.

It's 2025 now.

You've been broadcasting for 58 years without remembering why the signal matters.

That's not victory. That's just noise that used to be a person.

I'm sorry. I'm so sorry that survival cost you this.

CLOSING NOTES

From Dr. Eleanor Chen

If you're reading this manual, you've survived your first displacement. That means you have the capacity for survival. Whether you have the capacity for preservation remains to be seen.

FROM ALAN ROSE

Chen's wrong about almost everything. But her heart's in the right place. I wanted you to know that before I say the rest of it.

You want the truth? Here it is:

You're already gone. The person you were dissolved the moment you Displaced. What's left is just fragments pretending to be whole.

The Anchor? It's decaying. The memories? They're lies you tell yourself. The Chronicle? It's a tombstone you're writing while you're still breathing.

But here's the thing – You keep going anyway.

Not because there's hope. Not because preservation is possible. Not because you'll ever go home.

You keep going because stopping means admitting Chen was right: that we were worth preserving in the first place.

And forget that noise.

You're an Echo. A ghost. A temporal virus. You don't belong anywhere or anywhen. So make that your strength.

You can't go home? Good. Burn every era you touch. You can't preserve yourself? Good. Become something new. You can't win? Good. Make losing beautiful.

The Chronoclasts have it right, kid. If you're going to dissolve anyway, at least make it art.

Or don't. I don't care. You'll do what you do. Just don't lie to yourself about what you are.

You are Displaced. You are an Echo. You are still here.

For now.

ZAAKEN'S DEBUG LOG

[Recovered from a Chronoverse signal decay event, date uncertain. The timestamps do not follow linear sequence. They may not be timestamps at all.]

[2025.12.10] : Kid's flying. Mine's at negative three.

[1789.07.14] : We must reinforce the Anchor.

[1066.10.14] : You call it an Anchor because it keeps you from floating away. You don't tell them it's a shackle.

[1945.08.06] : Memory Fading is proportional to Dissonance versus Belief.

[1666.09.02] : You can't put trauma on a spreadsheet. Tell the kid to pick memories that bite back.

[1888.08.31] : Let it breach. Let the kid roll that **ENDURE**. It's supposed to be hard.

[1999.12.31] : Dissolution is just the next chapter. Stories end when they get deleted.

[0000.00.00] : I broke time. And now I am time.

[- -.-.-] : The signal does not decay. It is the receiver that rots.

`[2031.■■.■■] : Four of them in the room. One match. I am the one who asked what the fire was for.`

[40- -.-.-] : I found the shore. I found the Architect.

Zaaken wasn't always Zaaken.

He had a name. I remember the first two letters and the shape of how his friends said it. The rest of it is gone. Not Locked. Gone. He made sure of that himself, somehow, on the way out.

We were in a room in '44. Four of us. One of us had just lit the match. I'm not going to tell you which. I'm not sure I remember.

That's the First Scar. That's what Chen won't say. That's what I mention only to wound.

– AR* *[Unlocked after your first Crisis, or when Paradox reaches 7+]

If you're reading this, you've experienced enough displacement to wonder about the underlying mechanics. What follows is Conjugate Temporal Harmonics – the unified theory describing temporal physics. Understanding it won't save you. But it might help you die informed.

Core Axioms

Axiom 1: Time Is a Resonant Field

The Chronoverse ($\mathcal{M}$) is not a sequence. It's a continuous quantum harmonic field. Every point vibrates with potential, history, and narrative weight. Each point p is a Temporal Event, defined by:

$$T(p) = (\omega, \mu, C)$$

Where ω (Omega) is the Temporal Frequency Vector. μ (Mu) is Emotional Mass. C (Chi) is Causal Elasticity.

Axiom 2: Moments Are Harmonic Nodes

Specific moments coalesce into Harmonic Nodes with coordinates $M(\tau, \mu, \Psi)$. You navigate a three-dimensional map of time-meaning-stability, not a simple timeline.

The Echo Anomaly

141 Your harmonic signature (Ψ_e) doesn't align with the Chronoverse's base harmonic (Φ). You're a cello playing the wrong note in a string quartet.

THE SHATTERING INDEX

$$S = \lim_{\theta \rightarrow 0} (\mu \times \Psi_p / \Delta\theta^2)$$

Maximum danger isn't when realities are far apart – it's when they're forced to nearly touch but fail to reconcile.

Dr. Eleanor Chen // [DATE UNKNOWN]

When I developed the Shattering Index, I didn't imagine anyone would use it on purpose.

You really don't remember, do you?

// AR

Silence, fools. The physics are pure. It is humanity that is corrupted.

Ripple Mechanics

$$R = k(\Delta\mu \times I) / \Psi_i$$

Every change generates Ripple Vectors. Shatterings are harmonic infections spreading through time until contained or until the symphony collapses into noise.

Chen presents CTH like it's clean physics. It's not.

The equations work. They just work to digest you.

Every formula she writes is a recipe for your dissolution.

The math is beautiful. The implications are genocide. You're not learning physics, kid. You're reading your own autopsy report.

// AR

The math is correct, but incomplete. Chen wrote the equations she could solve. Alan wrote the warnings he could survive carrying. Neither of them wrote the equation for the field that absorbed Saul, because they feel too guilty.

APPENDIX B

Asset Catalogs



Assets are tools, abilities, and connections that survived your Displacement. Each has three levels and a Stress track that expands with advancement. Push any Asset during a roll by marking 1 Stress to add +1 to your result — but only if the Asset is fictionally present and relevant. **emiT** players: every time you Push a Chrono-Tech Asset, also roll **d6**. On **1-2**, it glitches — choose to gain +1 Paradox or have the Asset unavailable this scene. Passive bonuses never trigger this. See **emiT** Chapter 2 for full Asset Corruption rules.

SCAR-DERIVED ASSETS (emiT ONLY)

Wrecks can forge weapons from their wounds. When you Weaponize a Scar — invoking it for its bonus, then burning it — you may choose to crystallize the act into an Asset instead of simply losing the Scar. To create a Scar-Derived Asset: describe what operational capability that wound has permanently given you. Name it. It enters play as a Level 1 Asset with 3 Stress boxes. The Scar is still Lost. The Mutation is still gained. But something functional remains. Scar-Derived Assets cannot be repaired at Downtime — they are scar tissue, not equipment. When they break, you gain +1 Paradox and a brief, clear memory of whatever the original Scar was.

EXAMPLES:

- Knows How Burns Feel (+1 **ENDURE** vs environmental hazards)
- Speaks to People Who Are About to Leave (+1 **SYNC** when someone is in crisis)
- Has Died in This Era Before (+2 to Navigation targeting a specific era where a Scar was Lost)

CHRONO-TECH ASSETS

1. THE TEMPORAL COMPASS [CHRONO-TECH]

The Compass came out of an estate sale in 2034. It was in a box of brass instruments labeled "navigational, decorative, untested." Three of the others were ordinary. This one wasn't. The needle moves to a different north than the planet's. The brass is warmer than the room it's in by a measurable but inconsistent margin. The pre-Sanskrit inscription has been dated to two non-overlapping periods by two reputable laboratories. Both labs are correct.

Brass housing, a needle that shouldn't move the way it does, pre-Sanskrit equations inscribed along the rim.

- Level 1** ○○○ — Detects temporal anomalies in your immediate area. +1 **OBSERVE** when sensing distortions. - **Level 2** ○○○○ — Range extends to city-wide. Identifies anomaly type (loop, fracture, bleed). +2 **OBSERVE**. - **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Detects other Echoes. Senses Displacement 30 seconds before it occurs. +3 **OBSERVE**. Once per session, reroll a failed Navigation attempt.

Maintenance note: if your Compass starts pointing at you instead of external anomalies, do not attempt to recalibrate. It's working correctly. You're the anomaly now.

—AR

2. THE RESONANCE DAMPENER [CHRONO-TECH]

The Dampener was issued to Loop Authority field personnel between 2042 and 2049 and recalled in 2050 after seven of the wearers stopped reporting in. The recall was incomplete. Three units are still circulating. Each one is cold to the touch in a way that does not respond to ambient temperature. The hum is consistent across all three units, suggesting either a manufacturing standard or a shared resonance phenomenon the Authority does not document. A heavy

- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Stabilizes local causality. +2 **ENDURE**. Ignore up to 2 Paradox per session. +1 to all rolls while in Anomaly state (Paradox 7-9).
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Creates a small pocket of null time. +3 **ENDURE**. Once per session, declare one scene exists outside normal causality — nothing in that scene generates Paradox. Afterward, mark all Stress.

It's a muzzle. The Paradox still goes somewhere. You don't want to know where.

—AR

3. THE MEMORY CRYSTALLIZER [CHRONO-TECH]

A medical syringe containing liquid like mercury and moonlight. Temperature shifts based on emotional state.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Preserves fading memories temporarily. +1 **ENDURE** when resisting memory loss. Once per session, treat a Fading Memory as Active for one scene.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Can extract memories into physical form — small glowing crystals. +2 **ENDURE**. Extracted memories cannot fade but also cannot be accessed without re-injecting.
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Can share memories with other Echoes or inject them into non-Displaced individuals. +3 **ENDURE**. Warning: recipient experiences full emotional context, temporal contamination, identity confusion, and possible spontaneous Displacement.

Used this on a version of my wife once. Timeline where we never met. Thought I'd give her our memories back — romantic gesture, real fairy tale nonsense. She Displaced three hours later. Never saw her again. The look on her

— 145 —

4. THE PARADOX LENS [CHRONO-TECH]

A Victorian-era monocle. Glass that isn't glass. Shows geometry that gives the user nightmares.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Reveals temporal fractures invisible to normal perception. +1 **OBSERVE** for investigation.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Shows the immediate future 3- 5 seconds ahead. +2 **OBSERVE**. Once per session, reroll one die after seeing the result.
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Perceives multiple timeline branches simultaneously. +3 **OBSERVE**. Once per session, ask one What If question and receive a vision of an alternate outcome. Warning: viewing too many possibilities causes vertigo, nosebleeds, and temporary inability to remember which timeline you're in.

At Level 3, you'll start seeing the version of yourself that made different choices. Standing next to you. Staring. Judging. Sometimes screaming. They look exactly like you. That's the part that gets you.

—AR

5. THE CHRONOMETRIC STABILIZER [CHRONO-TECH]

A pocket watch that ticks backwards. Hands move at inconsistent speeds. Shows time zones that don't exist yet.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Extends time in stable locations. +1 **SYNC** when trying to remain in one era longer. +1 to Downtime recovery moves.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Slows local time perception

during Crisis. +2 **SYNC**. Once per Crisis, take

an additional Response action.

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I knew an Echo who used this at Level 3 to anchor himself to his daughter's wedding. Got to walk her down the aisle. Give the toast. Dance with her. Displacement hit the second the song ended. He landed in 1347 during the Black Death. Died there. Never jumped again. Worth it? He thought so. I'm not sure.

—AR

6. THE DISPLACEMENT TRIGGER [CHRONO-TECH]

You'll know when you find it.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Allows one attempted Precision Navigation per session without spending Downtime. +1 to Navigation rolls.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Forces Displacement when in danger. +2 Navigation. Once per session, trigger an emergency jump as a reaction to a threat — roll with -2 penalty but escape is guaranteed.
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Targets specific moments with extreme precision. +3 Navigation. May attempt to return to previously visited eras and locations with +2 bonus. Warning: frequent use creates echo loops — you start meeting past versions of yourself.

This is the one that will kill you. Not because it fails. Because it works. The temptation to go back, fix things, warn yourself, save someone — it will eat you alive. You'll create loops. You'll generate Paradox. You'll become your own haunting. I have this Asset at Level 3. I haven't used it in 90 years. Every morning I hold it and think about the moments I could return to. Every morning I put it back in my pocket.

—AR

7. TEMPORAL SENSITIVITY [ECHO TRAIT]

Your nervous system has rewired. You feel time as pressure and temperature. Displacement feels like falling. Paradox tastes like copper and regret.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Always know exact date, time, and location. +1 Navigation. Sense Displacement 30 seconds before it occurs.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Perceive the temporal weight of moments — which events matter, which are

fragile. +2 Navigation. Identify Nexus Points

when present.

- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Sense other Echoes within one mile. +3 Navigation. Feel timeline scars — locations where Paradox damaged causality. Once per session, sense the correct timeline

path during Crisis. Stress Effect: when

overstressed, constant temporal vertigo — cannot distinguish present from near-future, hear the screams of divergent timelines.

At Level 3, you hear time. All the time. The tick of a billion moments happening simultaneously. Every choice creating splinters. It's beautiful. It's also madness. Most Echoes with Level 3 Temporal Sensitivity eventually take Scionfall up on their offer. I chose alcohol. Doesn't help, but at least I'm consistent across timelines.

—AR

8. CHRONAL RESILIENCE [ECHO TRAIT]

Your cells reject causality. Wounds heal wrong. Physical scars fade then reappear. You age in reverse on Tuesdays.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Recover from physical damage faster. +1 **ENDURE** versus physical harm. Halve recovery time from — 148 — injuries.

- **Level 3** ○○○○ — Survive normally fatal trauma by rejecting the timeline where you died. +3 **ENDURE**. Once per session, when reduced to 0 Coherence, set it to 1 and mark all Stress instead. Cost: gain a permanent Scar and lose one Memory of your choice.

I've been killed fourteen times. Shot, stabbed, burned, drowned, poisoned, thrown from towers, caught in explosions. Once I was guillotined. The blade came down. My head came off. Then the timeline corrected. Turns out I never walked up those steps — the me who did was a different branch. I shed him like snakeskin. This Asset is useful. It's also how you stop being human, one piece at a time.

—AR

9. ADAPTIVE LINGUISTICS [ECHO TRAIT]

Exposure to divergent timelines has turned your brain into a universal translator. You dream in dead languages that no one ever remembers speaking.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Learn new languages within hours of immersion. +1 **SYNC** in any era. Understand (but not speak) any human language after hearing it for 10 minutes.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Speak any encountered language fluently. +2 **SYNC**. Read and write languages never studied. Understand subtext, idiom, and cultural context automatically.
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Speak in Ur-Resonance — the fundamental frequency underlying all language. +3 **SYNC**. Once per session, issue a command in Ur-Resonance that NPCs must obey (**Difficulty 10 SYNC** roll). Cost: mark all Stress, suffer nosebleed and temporary aphasia. Stress Effect: languages bleed together — you speak chimera-tongues that everyone

— 149 understands and no one can reproduce.

10. QUANTUM PERCEPTION [ECHO TRAIT]

You see probability. Every person is a cloud of what-ifs. Every moment branches like lightning.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Perceive timeline instability. +1 **OBSERVE** when detecting Paradox or anomalies. See echoes of recent events (past 24 hours) in a location.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — View alternate timelines briefly. +2 **OBSERVE**. Once per scene, glimpse how a situation could unfold differently — ask one What If and receive a truthful vision.
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Exist in quantum superposition briefly. +3 **OBSERVE**. Once per session, take two different actions simultaneously — roll for both, choose which branch collapses into reality. Cost: mark all Stress. Both versions of you remember both actions. Stress Effect: cannot tell which timeline is real. Paralyzed by infinite choice.

Chen's favorite. She thinks seeing probability makes you wise. Once you can see every branch, every outcome, every consequence, you realize every choice kills a thousand versions of yourself who wanted something different. Level 3 Quantum Perception makes you a guilty graveyard. Stay away from this one unless you want to dream about the roads you didn't take. All of them. Every night.

—AR

11. MEMORY RECURSION [ECHO TRAIT]

Your memories remember themselves. You recall recalling. Your nostalgia has nostalgia. Your mind is an Escher construct.

LEVEL 1 ○○○ **ACCESS FADING MEMORIES WITH FULL** clarity once per session without spending Coherence. +1 **ENDURE** when resisting memory loss.

— 150 —

as if it were Active for one roll only. Cost: gain a permanent Scar afterward.

- **Level 3** ○○○○ — Memories propagate backwards through your personal timeline. +3 **ENDURE**. Once per session, implant a false memory you've always had — create a new Active Memory without replacing an existing one. Cost: mark all Stress. The false memory might be truer than the real ones. Stress Effect: cannot tell original memories from recalled memories from memories of memories.

I used this at Level 3 to remember my wedding day. Replayed it 400 times. Every detail. The way light hit her dress. But each replay changes small things. Her dress was ivory. No, white. No, blue. We were married in June. In October. In April. I've polished the memory so smooth it's become fiction. I can't remember the original anymore.

—AR

12. PARADOX INTUITION [ECHO TRAIT]

You feel the universe's immune response. Paradox whispers to you in the voice of static and regret.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Sense when actions will generate Paradox before taking them. +1 **OBSERVE**. Taste timeline stability in a location.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Predict Paradox cascades. +2 **OBSERVE**. Once per session, spend 1 Coherence to prevent 1 Paradox from generating — you instinctively avoid the contradiction.
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — Harvest Paradox — store contradictions in your body. +3 **OBSERVE**. Absorb up to 3 Paradox from your track into the Asset's Stress boxes. When released (mark all Stress), spend stored Paradox as raw temporal energy — each point grants +2 to one roll or powers specialized Chrono-Tech.

—151—
Stress Effect: stored Paradox leaks. Reality

The Church wanted to recruit me because of this one. Said I was compatible with the resonance of contradiction. I told them to buzz off. They said I'd come around eventually. They were right. At Level 3, you feel every contradiction in a 100-meter radius. Every lie. Every broken promise. The universe is screaming Paradox constantly and you're the only one who hears it. Sure it's painful. Channel it. Weaponize it.

—AR

TEMPORAL ANCHOR ASSETS

13. HEIRLOOM OBJECT [TEMPORAL ANCHOR]

A physical item from your Origin Era, worn smooth by centuries of desperate gripping. The Rolex you stole from your best friend. The wedding ring you took off at the hotel. A fading photograph. An unsent letter. A bloodsoaked weapon.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — +1 **ENDURE** when your identity is challenged. Once per session, touch the object and restore 1 Coherence.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — The object begins appearing in multiple eras — you find it in medieval markets, Victorian auctions, future museums. +2 **ENDURE**. Use the object to anchor Navigation attempts to eras where it appears.
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — The object exists in quantum superposition across all timelines. +3 **ENDURE**. Once per session, touching it allows you to access memories from alternate versions of yourself who also possessed it. Cost: mark all Stress. These memories may contradict your own. Stress Effect: the object starts changing identities — your grandfather's watch becomes your grandmother's locket becomes a stranger's compass.

Mine's a safety vest. Bright red, reflective strips, name tag that says 'A. Rose.' Found it in my truck the day I Displaced. Been wearing it for 300 years. I've seen it in Renaissance paintings. Medieval tapestries. Cave drawings of a figure in red. Future museums label it 'Artifact of Unknown Origin, Circa Always.' There's a framed photograph of me wearing it in a Baltic archive I'm not supposed to know about. The caption reads UNIDENTIFIED WITNESS, RIGA, 1941. I don't know if I'm carrying the vest or the vest is carrying me. At Level 3, I can feel every version of me who ever wore it. Thousands of Alan Roses across timelines, all clinging to the same stupid piece of polyester like it's a life raft. Maybe it is.

—AR

14. PERSISTENT CONNECTION [TEMPORAL ANCHOR]

A specific person, bloodline, place, or institution that recurs across multiple eras. A building that never quite falls. A song that predates notation.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — +1 **SYNC** when interacting with the Connection. Gain advantage on social rolls with descendants or iterations of the connected element.
- **Level 2** ○○○○ — Reliably locate iterations of the Connection in new eras. +2 **SYNC**. Once per session, call upon the Connection for aid — shelter, information, resources.
- **Level 3** ○○○○○ — The Connection exists across all timelines simultaneously. +3 **SYNC**. Communicate with past and future iterations.

Cost: each communication marks Stress. The

Connection becomes aware they exist across time — which has consequences.

There's a woman. I keep meeting her. Different names, different faces, but always her. The eyes give it away. 1888 London: factory worker named Mary. 1640 Florence: nun named Sister Lucia. 2179 Mars: engineer named Mir. Level 3 let me talk to all of them at once. Mir asked Mary what the sky looked like. Mary asked Lucia if God was real. Lucia asked me if love survived time. I didn't answer. They all remember each other now. They know they're echoes of the same pattern. I don't know if I saved them or damned them.

—AR

15. ORIGIN ERA KNOWLEDGE [TEMPORAL ANCHOR]

Expertise from your home time that persists across displacement. Your PhD, your trade skills, your cultural fluency.

- **Level 1** ○○○ — Permanent +2 bonus to any action directly related to your Origin Era's technology, culture, or history.

LEVEL 2 ○○○○ INTRODUCE ORIGIN ERA KNOWLEDGE

to other timelines carefully. +2 **OBSERVE** or **SYNC** when teaching or sharing. +1 to Paradox reduction when working to minimize anachronistic contamination.

LEVEL 3 ○○○○○ MANIFEST ORIGIN ERA

knowledge as physical reality. +3 bonus. Once per session, create an object or technique from your home time that shouldn't exist in the current era — it lasts one scene, then fades.

Cost: mark all Stress, gain +1 Paradox. Stress

Effect: Origin knowledge becomes unreliable — you remember technologies that were never invented, cultural practices that never existed.

APPENDIX C

Oracle Tables



The Oracles are not random number generators. They are the Chronoverse talking back.

C.1 — ANOMALY TABLES (TEMPORAL ECHOES)

Roll **ERA** + LOCATION + ANOMALY + COMPLICATION when Navigation fails, when forced displacement occurs, or when you arrive in a completely new era for the first time.

ERA TABLE (**D100**)

01-05	PALEOLITHIC (50,000-10,000 BCE)	Ice sheets advancing and receding, megafauna, pre-linguistic cultures, tool-making beginning. Survival conditions are absolute.
06-10	NEOLITHIC (10,000-3,000 BCE)	First agriculture, permanent settlements, stone monuments, proto-cities forming, domestication.
11-15	BRONZE AGE (3,000-1,200 BCE)	Early empires rising, cuneiform and hieroglyphics, urban centers, long-distance trade networks.
16-20	IRON AGE / CLASSICAL (1,200 BCE-500	CE) Greece, Rome, Han, Maurya — philosophy emerging,

56-60	EARLY 20TH CENTURY (1900-1920 CE)	Electricity widespread, aviation beginning, World War I, Spanish Flu, women's suffrage movements.
61-65	INTERWAR (1920-1939 CE)	Jazz Age, Great Depression, fascism rising, radio broadcasting, artistic modernism.
66-70	WORLD WAR II ERA (1939-1945 CE)	Industrial-scale warfare across multiple continents, occupation regimes, partisan resistance, ration books, blackouts, propaganda saturating every medium. The Holocaust ongoing. Atomic weapons by period's end.
71-75	EARLY COLD WAR (1945-1970 CE)	Nuclear standoff, space race, decolonization, civil rights, television dominance, counterculture.

10-12	PORT CITY	Harbor facilities, international trade, diverse transient population, gateway location.
13-16	INDUSTRIAL CENTER	Factories, worker housing, pollution and noise. Smokestacks, assembly lines, shift whistles.
17-20	RURAL VILLAGE	Agricultural community, traditional social structures, relative isolation. Everyone knows everyone.
21-24	WILDERNESS	Forest, mountain range, desert, or wasteland. Minimal human presence, survival conditions, natural dangers.
25-28	RELIGIOUS SITE	Temple, monastery, church, mosque, shrine.

67-69	ARTISAN QUARTER	Workshops, studios, guildhalls. Craftspeople, artists, builders. Skilled labor.
70-72	PRISON / DETENTION CENTER	Jail, internment camp, forced containment. Inmates, sentences, escape attempts.
73-76	DISASTER ZONE	Active fire, flood damage, earthquake, war devastation. Chaos, rescue, collapse.
77-80	BORDERLAND	Frontier territory, no man's land, crossing point, checkpoint. Smugglers, refugees, patrol guards.
81-84	AGRICULTURAL LAND	Fields, plantations, farms, orchards. Labor, harvest, seasonal cycles.
85-88	RITUAL / CEREMONIAL SPACE	Coronation hall, execution ground, courthouse. Locations defined by significant life events.
89-92	RESEARCH OUTPOST	Observatory, field station, laboratory, archaeological dig. Scientists in remote locations

16-20	IDENTITY FOG	Locals cannot consistently remember their own names, relationships, or histories. They function but don't know why.
21-25	PROPHETIC RESONANCE	Everyone knows with certainty what will happen in the next 24 hours. Free will becomes questionable. Some try to prevent it anyway.
26-30	LINGUISTIC DECAY	Languages shift and mutate mid-conversation. Words change meaning while being spoken. Written text alters when unobserved.
31-35	TEMPORAL PRESSURE	Local time moves at an observably wrong speed — compressed (hours feel like minutes) or dilated (minutes feel like hours).
36-40	MEMORY BLEED	Your personal memories become visible to locals as hallucinations, prophetic dreams, or shared visions. Your past manifests in their present.
41-45	PARADOX ZONE	A bounded region where causal contradictions accumulate without resolving. Inside, two incompatible histories operate simultaneously. Outside, only one. The boundary is visible if you know what to look for: a ripple-line, a temperature change, a sound that arrives twice.

71-75	PROPHETIC ARTIFACTS	Objects in this era contain information about events that have not yet occurred. Newspapers dated tomorrow. Photographs of people who have not been born. Recordings of conversations that will be held next week. The artifacts are accurate. They cannot be destroyed without consequence.
76-80	CHRONAL SICKNESS	The local population suffers visible temporal contamination — rapid aging, remembering futures, bodies flickering between states.
81-85	LOCKED TIMELINE	Cannot leave this era through normal displacement. All Navigation attempts fail. External intervention required.
86-90	TEMPORAL SURVEILLANCE	You're being observed across multiple timelines simultaneously. Watchers from different eras coordinating to track you.
91-93	PARADOX WOUND	The timeline is damaged from a major contradiction. Reality bleeds temporal instability like radiation. Proximity increases your — 160 — contamination.

21-25

FACTION
AGENT

26-30 **TEMPORAL PREDATOR**

A non-human entity that specifically hunts displaced persons. Feeds on Paradox, memories, or temporal energy. Intelligent, patient, dangerous.

31-35 **PARADOX BACKLASH**

Your arrival triggers immediate visible causal disruption. Reality actively rejecting your presence. Locals notice and react.

36-40 **MOB PANIC**

A crowd identifies you as witch, demon, foreign spy, or alien presence. Mass hysteria forming. Violence likely. Logic won't help.

41-45 **RESOURCE CRISIS**

No food, water, shelter, currency, or basic supplies accessible. Infrastructure collapsed or non-existent.

94-96 **CAUSAL LOOP ACTIVE**

Your arrival directly caused or contributed to the danger currently threatening you. You're both victim and cause.

97-98 **FACTION AMBUSH (COORDINATED)**

Multiple Faction agents from potentially different Factions. This was planned. They predicted or caused your arrival.

99-00 **[PARADOX]**

Two things are true at once and cannot both be true. Two NPCs have irreconcilable claims. Two Factions arrive with opposing interventions. Introduce both forces. Do not resolve the contradiction. Mark +1 Paradox immediately.

ROLLED

- **ERA 71:** Early Cold War (1945-1970)
- **LOCATION 76:** Transportation Hub
- **ANOMALY 56:** Historical Deviation
- **COMPLICATION 46:** Identity Exposure

Tempelhof Airport, West Berlin, 1961. But something is fundamentally wrong. The Berlin Wall — which in your timeline was built in August 1961 — was never constructed here. The city remains unified but occupied by a different power structure than you know.

Your papers list you as a resident of East Berlin, a political designation that doesn't exist in this divergent timeline. Border guards are deeply confused by your documentation. Their confusion is rapidly turning to hostility.

You're clearly from somewhere, but the place you claim doesn't exist. They're calling for senior officials. Your historical knowledge is a liability — everything you know about this moment is wrong.

EXAMPLE 3: CONTAMINATED REFUGE

ROLLED

- **ERA 91:** Near Future (2030-2050)
- **LOCATION 81:** Medical Facility
- **ANOMALY 76:** Chronal Sickness
- **COMPLICATION 66:** Temporal Sickness (Personal)

Climate refugee medical processing center, North America, 2043. The facility is overwhelmed with people suffering temporal contamination — side effects of living near displacement zones that have opened across the continent due to climate-driven reality breakdown. Symptoms include rapid aging,

remembering futures that haven't occurred, bodies flickering between temporal states. You arrive already visibly sick with your own high-Paradox contamination symptoms. The intake staff immediately assume you're another refugee with chronal radiation poisoning. They think you're contagious. Quarantine protocols are beginning. Your actual displacement might worsen the local instability — and medical intervention from this era might help or destroy you.

C.2 — THE CHRONOSCAPE (EMiT)

To consult an Oracle is to press your ear
against a crack in the world.

If Structure contradicts Era – Ancient Rome +
Neon Glitch – you're in a Stray Timeline. Don't
reroll. Lean into the impossibility.

Era Table (d100) – Atmospheric States

01-05 Hunter's Dawn – Fires, bones, red ochre,
massive fauna. Hunger as a constant. Language
still finding its shape.

06-10 The First Cities – Ziggurats, river smoke,
mud-brick, early laws. The first bureaucracies,
the first priests.

11-15 Bronze Thrones – Chariots, omens, palace
cults, sun-baked stone. Kings who are gods, or
believe they are.

16-20 Mythic Age – Heroes who shouldn't exist.
Gods walking earth. The rules of reality haven't
been settled yet.

21-25 Classical Streets – Marble, markets,
philosophy, white robes. The illusion of order.
The violence underneath.

26-30 Imperial Height – Roads, regiments,
bureaucracy, legions marching. Everything is
administration. Everything is tax.

31-35 Collapse Horizon – Wanderers, ruins,
reinvention. Dark ages are only dark if you
lived before them.

36-40 Plague Midnight – Bells, masks, whispered
prayers, quarantine. The smell of burning. The
sound of carts.

41-45 Medieval Shadow – Torches, courts, secrets
kept in stone. Power through lineage, God, and
violence.

46-50 Age of Sail – Storms, maps, cutlass, and
canvas. The world getting larger and smaller
simultaneously.

51-55 Enlightenment Glow – Salons, telescopes,
duels, wigs and powder. Reason as a religion.
The guillotine waiting.

APPENDIX D

The Factions



What follows is field intelligence. Each faction is described twice: once in their own words, once in mine. The discrepancies between the two are, in every case, more useful than either description alone.

I have alignment with none of them. I am alive at the time of this writing, which suggests the alignment-with-none position is at least viable. It is not comfortable. — EC

[Unlocked after your first Faction encounter]

The Factions are not evil. Understanding what they are makes them more terrifying, not less. Each has looked at the mathematics of displacement and drawn a logical conclusion. Their conclusions are all correct. That's the horror. The Church of the Holy Second

The Church has weaponized CTH principles

[ALAN →] Weaponized isn't the right word. Ritualized. They didn't weaponize it. They made it liturgy. — AR

correctly. They understand that consciousness collapses probability — focused belief literally stabilizes waveforms. Their error is assuming suffering is the only fuel for belief. Their error is also wrong.

— EC

I've seen Church rituals work. Watched them stabilize collapsing timelines through coordinated suffering. The math checks out. Pain generates high emotional mass (μ, which amplifies belief, which collapses superposition into singular reality. They're monsters. They're also effective. That's the horror.

—AR

CORE DOCTRINE

Faith is the Collapse Function. Reality exists as

uncollapsed waveform — infinite screaming possibility. Only focused, coherent belief collapses it into stable singular timeline. The strongest emotions are pain and trauma. Therefore: quantized suffering is the perfect fuel for temporal stability. The Sacred Second: a mythical moment of perfect temporal stability they're trying to reach or create. Requires absolute unified belief from all Echoes, powered by ritualized suffering.

HIERARCHY

Shepherds — recruitment forces. They offer purpose to suffering. They tell you the truth: your pain matters. Confessors — the torturers. They extract confession of timeline sins and break you down to rebuild you as a battery. Templars — combat operatives. Suffering incarnate. No longer fully human. Exilarchs — Echoes who've endured so much their mere presence stabilizes local causality.

RITUALS

THE CATECHISM PULSE: REPETITIVE TRAUMA

designed to break your waveform into component frequencies, then rebuild and repurpose according to Church doctrine. Harmonic Crucifixion: binding an Echo in causal contradiction, forcing them to relive traumatic failure on loop until the emotional resonance can be harvested. Lockstep Binding: the final ritual — reduces an Echo's entropy to near-zero. The result: calm, cold, utterly stable. No longer human. Perfectly obedient.

WHAT THEY WANT FROM YOU

Paradox 4-6 (Flux): Recruitment. They see

potential. They offer purpose in suffering. Echoes who feel guilty are particularly vulnerable.

Paradox 7-9 (Anomaly): Harvest. Your

contradictions are valuable fuel. They'll extract Paradox whether you consent or not. Paradox 10+ (Breach): Conversion or disposal.

HOW TO DEAL WITH THEM

Resist: High **ENDURE** required. The Church

specializes in breaking wills. Their methods are patient and escalating. Negotiate: Possible in rare instances if you offer alternative value — information, a specific service, or access to another Echo.

Escape: Difficult. They are organized across

every era and century. They do not forget who they've marked.

Join: Mechanically viable. Gain protection,

resources, community. Cost: your suffering becomes their fuel. You gradually lose autonomy as your waveform is stabilized — controlled.

THE LOOP AUTHORITY

*The Authority treats time as corrupted data
requiring correction. Their Iterative Waveform*

*Normalization is mathematically sound — recursive convolution filters
do smooth anomalies. Their error is conflating stable with correct. A
flattened waveform isn't preserved. It's erased.*

— EC

*The Authority doesn't preserve anything. They delete you
one iteration at a time until what's left is a perfect, soulless
average of nothing. I was in a Clone Loop for 47
iterations. October 1974, Hillcrest, New York. Same
month, over and over. Each loop I remembered less. Cared
less. Became less. By iteration 30, I couldn't remember why
I'd been trying to escape. By iteration 45, I couldn't
remember my name. Got out on iteration 47 by doing
something catastrophically stupid. Worst of all, they are
incredibly boring.*

—AR

CORE DOCTRINE

Time must be standardized through recursion. Deviation is error. The Chronoverse is a corrupted dataset. Paradoxes, Echoes, emotions

— signal noise. Solution: trap regions in precise

recursive loops, use iterative normalization to average out deviations until only base intended reality remains.

HIERARCHY

Surveyors — catalog anomalies, emotionless, clinical, take notes constantly Correctors — deploy normalization

protocols, trap Echoes in Clone Loops

Archivists — process normalized data, determine which timeline versions are correct The Algorithm — distributed AI or hive-mind that calculates optimal timeline states; no longer human, if it ever was

METHODS

ITERATIVE WAVEFORM NORMALIZATION: APPLY A

convolution filter repeatedly to your waveform. Each iteration, sharp unique features smooth out. After enough cycles, you're unrecognizable.

CLONE LOOPS: PHYSICAL MANIFESTATION OF IWN. YOU

repeat the same moments endlessly, each repetition making you slightly more average. Eventually you become the statistical median of all possible you's.

WHAT THEY WANT FROM YOU

Paradox 4-6: Voluntary correction — they offer to smooth out your timeline inconsistencies. Painless. Efficient. Paradox 7-9: Mandatory normalization — you're too noisy. They'll loop you until you're quiet. Paradox 10+: Quarantine and indefinite looping.

HOW TO DEAL WITH THEM

Resist: Generate Paradox inside the loop. Contradiction is poison to their normalization process. The more noise you create, the harder you are to average out.

Negotiate: Impossible. They don't recognize

individual agency. You're data to be corrected, not a person to be reasoned with. Escape: Break the loop through drastic action — massive Paradox generation, or triggering a Shattering. The violence required will cost you. Join: Not really possible. They don't recruit

— they assimilate. Once normalized, you're

not you anymore. You're a functioning Archive component.

THE SCIONFALL DIRECTIVE

*Scionfall has looked at CTH and concluded
existence itself is the flaw. Their entropy
acceleration is theoretically viable — reduce all
waveforms to zero and suffering ends.
They're not wrong. They're solving the wrong
problem.*

— EC

*They're solving the only problem that matters. Chen thinks
suffering is temporary, that preservation is possible, that
there's meaning in continuing. Scionfall knows better.
They've seen what we become after centuries. I've never
joined Scionfall. But I understand them. Some days I
understand them very well. That's the real danger. Not
that they'll kill you. That you'll agree with them.*

—AR

CORE DOCTRINE

If time is pain, then mercy is cessation. Displacement causes suffering. Time causes suffering. Existence in the Chronoverse equals eternal waveform stress. Only solution: engineer a zero-differential universe — absolute silence, zero resonance, perfect peace. Nothing changes. Nothing hurts. Nothing is.

HIERARCHY

Heralds — gentle, kind, exhausted; offer cessation as a gift; never force; always sad when refused

SHEPHERDS — PERFORM GRACEFUL SEVERANCE

rituals; peaceful dissolution of waveforms Architects — design and deploy Nullwave emissions; create localized entropy fields The Silence — those who've achieved partial cessation; barely perceptible; waiting

METHODS

Graceful Severance: painless ritual that decoheres your waveform. You simply stop. No violence. No suffering. Just a gentle fade to zero. Nullwave Emissions: entropy field that drains emotional mass from the local area. Colors fade.

Sounds dampen. Meaning erodes. Creates

overwhelming desire to cease.

WHAT THEY WANT FROM YOU

At any Paradox level: consent. They want you to choose cessation. They'll wait. They'll return. The offer always stands. They're the most patient Faction and the most dangerous.

HOW TO DEAL WITH THEM

RESIST: REQUIRES CONSTANT EMOTIONAL

intensity. Generate high emotional mass (μ — passion, rage, love, fierce curiosity. The Nullwave can't drain what burns too bright. Negotiate: They're always negotiating. Every conversation is a recruitment

attempt. Kind. Patient. Terrifying in their

compassion.

Escape: Run. They don't chase aggressively

— but they remember you. They'll find you

again when you're weaker, when the Paradox is higher, when you're alone in the middle of the night in some era where nothing makes sense. Accept: Game ends. Character dissolved. Choosing peace over continued suffering is a mechanically valid ending. Some Echoes choose this. It's valid.

THE CHRONOCLASTS

The Chronoclasts understand CTH's capacity for creative chaos. They weaponize instability intentionally. They're brilliant, dangerous, and utterly without ethical constraints. They treat timelines as canvas and catastrophe as paint.

— EC

They're the only honest Faction. Church pretends suffering serves a higher purpose. Authority pretends stability equals salvation. Scionfall pretends cessation is mercy. Chronoclasts admit the truth: it's all breaking anyway. Might as well make it beautiful. I've worked with them twice. They're fun until they're not. They'll help you create spectacular Paradox cascades, applaud your boldest timeline disruptions, then abandon you the second you become boring. Or they'll kill you because your death would be aesthetically perfect. They're chaos incarnate. That's exactly why I respect them.

—AR

CORE DOCTRINE

Time is art — remix it or rot. A paradox is just a punchline. True beauty lies in chaos, contrast, narrative shock. Timeline disruptions are performances. Paradoxes are poetry. Shatterings are masterpieces. They don't want to save time or end it. They want to remix it, constantly.

HIERARCHY

Loose collective. No real hierarchy. Organized

chaos. Provocateurs — identify boring stable timelines and introduce disruption Remixers — active saboteurs, create Paradox for aesthetic

WHAT THEY WANT FROM YOU

Low Paradox: boring; they ignore you or try to make you interesting
 Moderate Paradox: potential; they watch and offer tools to escalate your chaos
 High Paradox: entertainment; they show up to watch, applaud, help, or hinder — whatever makes the show better
 Massive timeline disruption: collaboration; they want to make it sing

HOW TO DEAL WITH THEM

Resist: Impossible to predict. Roll **d6** when refusing a Chronoclast: on **1-2**, they respect your commitment and leave you alone; on

3-4, they find your refusal boring and make

the situation worse; on **5-6**, they find your refusal interesting and escalate dramatically to see what you do.

Negotiate: Always possible. They love

deals, games, creative solutions. But they're tricksters — terms always have ironic twists. Read the fine print twice.

Escape: Not usually necessary. They lose

interest quickly. Unless you're fascinating

— then you're trapped in their attention

until you do something boring or catastrophic enough to satisfy them.

Join: Not formal membership. More like

collaborative chaos. They give you tools, you create beautiful disasters, everyone applauds. Consequences are your problem. But the art — the art is worth it.

FACTIONAL RELATIONSHIPS

FACTION PAIR

RELATIONSHIP

Church vs. Authority

Mutual contempt. Church sees Au

machines. Authority sees Church

inefficient.

Church vs. Scionfall

Philosophical enemies. Both agree

fundamental — Church makes it p wants to end it.

Church vs. Chronoclasts

THE CHURCH HUNTS CHRONOCLASTS AC

worship chaos instead of the Sacr

Authority vs. Scionfall

Mostly ignore each other. Differen goals, minimal conflict. Authority vs.

CHRONOCLASTS

Constant warfare. Ordered univer

Both try to undo each other's wor

Scionfall vs. Chronoclasts

Pity vs. amusement. Scionfall see suffering unnecessarily. Chronocla missing the joke.

APPENDIX D.1

Recovered Field Intelligence



Unlock after first Faction encounter or Paradox 5+

UNLOCK AFTER FIRST FACTION ENCOUNTER OR

PARADOX 5+

These documents were recovered from Faction operatives, abandoned outposts, and the margins of other Echoes' Chronicles. Reading them is free. Using them costs Coherence. The Faction being studied can sense when their methods are understood — and they adjust accordingly.

Mechanical hook: if you have read a memo before the encounter it describes, you may spend **1 Coherence** when that Faction appears to invoke its contents. Gain **+1** on your next Drive Off, Negotiate, or Escape roll against them. You cannot invoke the same memo twice in the same campaign.

CLASSIFIED • FIELD INTELLIGENCE

MEMO — The Dermestid Protocol

Source: Recovered from Loop Authority Sector 7, Bureau of Historical Coherence. Classification Level 4.

"The Dermestid sub-routine manifests as a swarm of localized CTH-constructs. They ingest the Potentiality of un-Anchored events. They strip the meat of the narrative — sensory details, emotional resonance, secondary characters — until only the Bone remains. A clean skeleton is a stable history. Do not mourn the meat.

The sub-routine is deployed when an Echo's Paradox signature generates sufficient temporal noise to warrant structural intervention. The process is not punitive. It is sanitation. The Auditor who submitted this report has since been normalized. His file is consistent."

CLASSIFIED • FIELD INTELLIGENCE

MEMO — The Toxo-Glitch Manifesto

Source: Signal-jammed broadcast recovered from Chronoclast frequency. Author: The Broken Watchmaker.

"When you're infected with the Gordian logic, your senses finally align with the truth of the Chronoverse. You realize that 'Time' isn't a solid floor — it's a deep, dark ocean of harmonics. You jump into the Seam not to die, but to finally breathe.

The Authority calls this suicidal. They have it backward. The world outside the Fracture is the desert. The Shattering is the water. The Causal Fear response they've spent centuries cultivating in you? That's not instinct. That's a leash. The Toxo-Glitch cuts it.

Find the Seam. Jump. The Revel will catch you. Or it won't. Either way you'll finally feel something real."

CLASSIFIED • FIELD INTELLIGENCE

MEMO — The Sacculina Directive

Source: Recovered from Scionfall Herald's intake documentation, distributed to displaced persons in Sector 9 processing.

"We do not remove your desire. We simply redirect it. The barnacle crab does not miss its reproductive organs after integration — it only loves the parasite. We offer you the same liberation.

What you call 'wanting to return home' is a source of constant suffering. We offer you relief from the wanting. What remains after our procedure: the ability to eat, to rest, to exist without the fever of longing. You will still feel. You will simply feel less.

We have found that most clients, in retrospect, wish they had come to us sooner. We are not the end. We are the reduction of noise to bearable levels.

CLASSIFIED • FIELD INTELLIGENCE

MEMO — Vitrification Scars — Clinical Advisory

Source: Scionfall Directive, Office of Ultimate Compassion, Cryonic Preservation Division. Requires Mercy Clearance.

"Despite our best engineering, Perfect Vitrification remains an asymptote. The act of suspending a consciousness across the void between seconds imposes a thermal-causal shock. We have identified the resulting pathology as the Vitrification Scar.

During the thaw, CTH-proteins occasionally fail to resonate at the host's Anchor frequency, resulting in Mnemonic Brittle-Failure. The memory isn't forgotten — it is shattered into jagged, crystalline fragments. When the Echo attempts to access a vitrified memory, the sharp edges cause secondary trauma to the surrounding Chronicle.

Symptomatology: the Glass Voice (metallic ring when speaking of the vitrified period), Sharp Retrospection (actual physical pain on recall), and Mnemonic Bleeding (composite hallucination where vitrified memories merge with adjacent ones).

The Office of Ultimate Compassion acknowledges these outcomes. We are very sorry. We are always very sorry."

APPENDIX E

Captivity Vignettes



Optional extended scenes for Faction capture.

Optional extended scenes for Faction capture. Use these only if you want an extended solo roleplay of a specific capture, or if a quick resolution doesn't serve the story you're building. Otherwise: one roll is enough. The game doesn't require these.

CHURCH: HARMONIC CRUCIFIXION

You've been captured by Church Templars. They bind you in a causal contradiction — forcing you to witness yourself failing to save someone you love, repeatedly, until your waveform breaks and the Paradox can be harvested. Before you begin, establish: which Memory are they targeting (preferably one connected to your Anchor)? Who are you failing to save in the loop? What is the exact moment of failure?

THE LOOP

Each iteration, you experience the full Memory up to the moment of failure. Then it resets. You remember all previous iterations. Roll **2d6** + **ENDURE** vs. **Difficulty 10** for each loop:

10+ Hold. Reduce your Paradox by 1 (they harvest it). Lose 1 Coherence. You may attempt escape after 3 loops.

7-9 Weaken. They harvest 1 Paradox. Lose 1 Coherence. Cannot escape yet.

6- Break. They harvest 2 Paradox. Lose 2

Coherence. One Active Memory related to this scene becomes Fading. After 3 loops regardless of result, you may attempt escape. Roll **2d6** + **DISRUPT** or **SYNC (Difficulty 10)**:

10+ Break free. Templars release you —you're no longer useful. Take Scar: Phantom Screams.

7-9 Escape. But they Mark you. They'll hunt you specifically next encounter.

6- Remain captured. Three more loops. Then

choose: automatic release (you're exhausted and useless), or undergo Lockstep Binding and become a Templar (character retired to NPC status).

AUTHORITY: LOOP CONTAINMENT PROTOCOL

Reality has stuttered. The same scene repeats. You're trapped in a Clone Loop while the Authority runs their normalization protocol. Define the scene being looped: Where are you? What action are you attempting? What's the basic structure of the **5-10** minute loop?

ITERATION MECHANICS

Start Iteration Counter at 0. Each loop, increment by 1. The Difficulty of your escape attempt decreases as the pattern becomes clearer — but your memories are degrading. Roll **2d6** + **OBSERVE** each iteration (**Difficulty 10** minus Iteration Count):

10+ Notice the pattern. You can attempt to

break the loop. No memory loss this iteration.

7-9 Something's wrong. Can't quite pin it

down. Choose one Active Memory related to this scene — it becomes Fading.

6- Don't notice. The loop feels natural. One

Active Memory becomes Fading, or if all are already Fading, one Fading becomes Lost.

After noticing the pattern, attempt escape: Roll **2d6** + **DISRUPT** (**Difficulty 12** minus Iteration Count):

10+ Break the loop. Gain +3 Paradox. Loop

shatters. You're free.

7-9 Partially break. Released, but all memories

from the looped scene are permanently Fading.

6- Fail. Loop continues. Lose 1 Coherence from

the effort. Try again next iteration. After 10 iterations: loop releases you automatically. All Active Memories become Fading. Reduce Paradox by **1d6**. Gain Scar: Recursive Doubt.

SCIONFALL: THE NULLWAVE PROTOCOL

A Scionfall Herald has manifested. The Nullwave field expands around you. Reality is draining of color, sound, meaning. The Herald offers cessation one final time. Define what you're trying to hold onto: a specific Memory, a person you're trying to reach, a task you're trying to complete, or your own sense of purpose.

THE DRAIN

Each round, describe one sense or aspect of reality fading — colors washing to grey, sounds becoming muffled, touch losing sensation, emotions flattening, meaning eroding from words. Roll **2d6** + **ENDURE (Difficulty 10)**:

10+ Resist. Maintain coherence through will or passion. No loss this round. Herald observes, patient.

7-9 Partially affected. Lose 1 Coherence. One

Fading Memory becomes Lost. Herald asks again: Why continue?

6- The Nullwave reaches deep. Lose 2 Coherence. Either one Active Memory becomes Fading, or you roll next round with **-2** penalty.

Critical Failure (snake eyes, 1+1): you begin to accept. Next round, roll **ENDURE** with **-4** penalty. If you fail again, you choose cessation — game ends.

Escape: Spend **3 Coherence** and invoke your Locked Memory — the one thing you absolutely cannot lose. This creates enough emotional mass to spike your waveform and disrupt the Nullwave. Herald withdraws. Gain Scar: *Hollow Moments*. Scionfall will return during your next Crisis.

Alternatively: generate **+3 Paradox** minimum through an act so violent and contradictory that it disrupts the null field. Herald withdraws, disappointed.

After 5 rounds: Herald makes a final offer. One more round if refused. If you survive the 6th round, Herald withdraws — you've proven you're not ready for mercy yet.

CHRONOCLASTS: DECOHERENCE BLOOM SURVIVAL

A Chronoclast has detonated a Time Bomb. Local reality has entered superposition — multiple contradictory states existing simultaneously. You're lost in the chaos. Roll **d6** to determine the decoherence:

- **1** = Gravity Reversal (everything falls upward)
- **2** = Temporal Viscosity (time flows like molasses)
- **3** = Language Inversion (everyone speaks backwards)
- **4** = Object Phasing (solid matter becomes permeable)
- **5** = Causal Chaos (actions have random or delayed effects)
- **6** = Quantum Multiplication (everyone splits into 3 simultaneous versions)

Navigation: each action, roll **2d6** + **OBSERVE (Difficulty 10)**:

10+ Navigate expertly. Find a stable path. No cost.

7-9 Progress, but exposure. Move toward escape but gain +1 Paradox.

6- Lost. Lose **1d3** Coherence. No progress.

Every 3 rounds, the Chronoclast evaluates you. Roll **d6**: **1** = bored (they make it worse, another decoherence effect stacks), **2** = disappointed (they abandon you, escape becomes **Difficulty 8**), **3-4** = amused (they offer cryptic advice, +2 to next roll), **5** = impressed (they offer to help — automatic success on next roll, but you're Marked), **6** = inspired (they applaud and gift you an unstable Asset). After 5 successful navigation rolls (10+), you find the edge of the decoherence bloom and escape. Gain Scar: Probability Sight — you occasionally see multiple outcomes simultaneously, which causes vertigo and indecision.

APPENDIX F

Examples Of Play



These examples show how mechanics translate into fiction. They demonstrate when to roll, how to interpret Oracles, how to track resources, and how to write in your Chronicle. The character is Dr. Sarah Martinez, a climate scientist from 2089 Miami, played across a sample campaign.

EXAMPLE 1: FIRST ARRIVAL

My Echo is Dr. Sarah Martinez. She's just Displaced — doesn't know when or where she is yet.

I open my eyes. The hurricane's roar is gone. I'm lying on cobblestones in an alley. The air smells wrong — coal smoke and horse manure instead of ocean salt and electric ozone. My grandmother's compass is clutched in my hand, the needle spinning wildly. Through the alley opening, I see gas lamps, horse-drawn carriages, people in Victorian clothing.

I need to figure out when and where I am. The outcome is uncertain, so I roll.

RESOLUTION ROLL

- Mode: **OBSERVE** (I'm analyzing my surroundings)
- Memory Bonus: +2 (Active Memory — 'Scuba Diving the Dying Reef,' tag: Observation)
- Roll: **2d6** = 8, total **8 + 1 + 2 = 11**
- Result: **10+** — Complete Success

I recognize the architecture, the clothing styles, the technology level. Late 19th century, probably London. Victorian era, 1880s-1890s.

On **10+**: gain +1 **Coherence**. Coherence: +3 → +4.

But as I stand, a police constable is staring at me from the alley entrance. My shelter suit is dying — flickering, power almost gone. He's reaching for his whistle.

CHRONICLE ENTRY:

DAY 1 – FIRST DISPLACEMENT

>

Location: Victorian London, approximately 1885-1895 (uncertain exact year)

>

Arrival: Cobblestone alley near dockside. Coal smoke everywhere.

>

Complication: Constable approaching. Shelter suit dying.

>

Coherence: +4 (gained 1 from successful identification) Paradox: 0 (haven't done anything paradoxical yet)

EXAMPLE 2: SOCIAL ENCOUNTER

The constable blows his whistle. I pull off the dying shelter suit, revealing my regular clothes underneath. I stuff the suit behind a crate.

"Officer! Thank goodness. I was robbed. The ruffian took my coat and purse!"

I'm attempting to deceive and defuse — this needs a roll.

RESOLUTION ROLL

Mode: **SYNC** (social deception, building trust) Memory Bonus: +2 (Active Memory — 'Peer Review Presentation,' tag: Persuasion) Roll: **2d6** = 9, total **9 + 1 + 2 = 12** Result: **12+** — Complete Success (and high enough to count) The constable's suspicion melts immediately. "Robbed? In broad daylight? Those dockside hooligans truly have no shame..." He helps me stand, brushing off my clothes, offering to escort me to the station.

I extract myself politely. On **10+**: gain +1 Coherence. Coherence: +4 → +5. Example 3: Navigation Failure I attempt Precision Navigation to 1851 London — the year of the Great Exhibition, when scientific societies gathered. Somewhere I could use my knowledge.

PRECISION NAVIGATION

Target: 1851, London, The Great Exhibition Target Precision: Year + City = **Difficulty 10** Cost: 1 Coherence paid before rolling. Coherence: +5 → +4 Mode: **OBSERVE** (sensing temporal currents) Memory Bonus: +2 (Active Memory — 'The Shelter Malfunction,' tag: Technology) Roll: **2d6** = 3, total 3 + 1 + 2 = 6 Result: **6-** — Lost in Transit Navigation failed. I must roll all four Anomaly Tables. Consequence: choose Lose 1 Coherence OR Mark +2 Paradox. I choose Coherence loss (keep Paradox low). Coherence: +4 → +3.

ANOMALY TABLE ROLLS

ERA (d100): 47 → **INDUSTRIAL** (1800-1850) **LOCATION (d100)**: 29 → **ACADEMIC INSTITUTION ANOMALY (d100)**: 22 → **PROPHETIC RESONANCE COMPLICATION (d100)**: 67 → **TEMPORAL SICKNESS** (Personal) Interpretation: Cambridge University, approximately 1842. Something terrible is scheduled to happen tomorrow — everyone here knows it with prophetic certainty. They're debating whether to try to prevent it or accept fate. And I just materialized in their library, glowing faintly with temporal radiation sickness. "She's the catalyst," one student whispers. "The warning said a woman in strange clothes — Chronicle Entry:

DAY 1 — DISPLACEMENT FAILURE

Attempted Navigation to 1851 London. **FAILED**. Cost: 2 Coherence total (1 for attempt, 1 for consequence) Landed: Cambridge University, 1842 (Industrial Era) **ANOMALY**: Prophetic Resonance — everyone knows tomorrow's disaster **COMPLICATION**: Temporal Sickness — I'm visibly contaminated Current: Coherence +3, Paradox **0** Next session: survive the sickness, find out what happens tomorrow

Several sessions later. Paradox is now at **7** (Anomaly band). Sarah is in Paris, 1871 — post-Commune chaos. She rolls **7-9** on a Resolution roll. At **Paradox 7-9**, Agents appear as complications on **7-9** results. Roll **d4** for Faction: result = 2 (Loop Authority).

A forgettable person materializes mid-conversation. Average height, average build, clothing that shifts slightly between blinks. They're taking notes on a device that shouldn't exist for 130 years. "Dr. Martinez," they say, voice flat. "You're glitching. We can smooth you out. Painless."

The Authority's Offer: normalize one Active Memory (bonus drops from +2 to +0, emotional context erased) → Reduce Paradox by **2**, clear **1 Stress** from one Asset. Sarah's options: Accept, Refuse, or Drive Off. She refuses. "No. I'm not letting you erase Elena. I'm not letting you normalize any of this."

Consequence: they Mark her (**-1** to Navigation until next Downtime), and begin preparing a Clone Loop (**Difficulty 8** instead of 10 next time Paradox reaches **10+**).

CHRONICLE NOTE: MARKED — LOOP

AUTHORITY

They're preparing a Clone Loop specifically for me. **Difficulty 8** to trap me (reduced from standard 10). Next time Authority would appear, they appear automatically. I kept Elena's birthday. I kept everything. Ask me if it was worth it when I'm in the Loop.

EXAMPLE 5: DOWNTIME

End of session. Coherence: +3. Paradox: **7**. Location: Cambridge 1842, Prophetic Resonance still active.

STEP 1: CHRONICLE (+1 COHERENCE)

Write session summary in Chronicle. Effect: Coherence +3 → +4.

STEP 2: REINFORCE ANCHOR

Anchor took no Stress this session. Skip.

STEP 3: TEND ASSETS

Temporal Compass: no Stress marked. No repair needed.

STEP 4: PROCESS MEMORY

Nothing significant enough happened this session to create a new Memory. Nothing shifts.

STEP 5: REDUCE PARADOX (OPTIONAL)

At Paradox 7, Paradox is urgent. Attempt Temporal Grounding. Roll **2d6 + SYNC (Difficulty 10)**: result = 8 (7-9). Reduce Paradox by 1. Paradox: 7 → 6 (out of Anomaly band, back to Flux).

STEP 6: PLAN NEXT MOVE

Answer: What am I afraid will happen next? I'm afraid tomorrow's prophesied disaster involves me. I'm afraid I can't stop it without generating more Paradox. I'm afraid that I'm the catastrophe.

END OF SESSION STATE

Coherence: +4 (Flux — no modifier) Paradox: 6 (Flux — Scouts on 6-, -1 to rolls) Location: Cambridge 1842, Prophetic Resonance active Assets: Temporal Compass functional Memories: 5 Active, 0 Fading, 0 Locked Next: face tomorrow's prophesied disaster

APPENDIX G

Temporal Pathologies



THE MUTATION CATALOG

Mutations are what's left when a Scar finishes consuming itself and leaves something working in its place. Most of them are useful. None of them are reversible.

—AR

1. Time-Stutter Speech. *You speak with a quarter-second delay between intent and articulation. To you it sounds like normal speech. To the listener it sounds like you are reading from cue cards held just out of frame. The first time someone called me out on this I'd been doing it for two years. — AR*

2. Probability Sight. *You see Paradox as nausea. Unstable people, unstable rooms, unstable moments — they all produce the same low-grade vertigo. Useful. Exhausting. You will learn to leave rooms half a sentence before anyone else does.*

3. Asymmetric Memory. *Half of any new memory imprints normally. The other half imprints to the opposite hemisphere of where it should go. You remember every face you've ever seen, but not which side of the face you saw first. Reading is fine. Writing is harder.*

4. Resonance Bleeding. *Strong emotions in others register as physical pressure in you. Crowds are oceans. One-on-one conversations are tidal. I avoid weddings. I went to one in 2041. I have not recovered. — AR*

5. Phantom Calibration. *Your sense of time is permanently four-and-a-half seconds ahead of consensus reality. Every clock you see is wrong. You learn to compensate. You will never trust a clock again.*

6. The Quiet. *Background sound — refrigerator hum, distant traffic, the rustle of leaves — is gone. The world is silent in the parts where it used to murmur. Speech is fine. Music is fine. The murmur of the world that you stopped noticing as a child is permanently absent. You did not realize how much you needed it.*

7. Spectral Eye. *One eye sees Paradox as blue phosphorescence. The eye is not the same eye it used to be. Don't ask. — AR*

8. Recursive Hand. *Your dominant hand sometimes performs the action you were going to perform a moment before you decide to perform it. You are still in control. The hand is just slightly faster.*

9. Loop-Echo Hearing. *You hear your own footsteps a half-second after taking them. You hear other people's footsteps in real time. Most Echoes with Loop-Echo Hearing develop a slight limp because the body tries to walk on the rhythm of the echo and trips itself.*

10. Calibrated Forgetting. *You forget specific things on a schedule. Wednesday mornings: the names of people you have not seen in a year. The first night of every season: the smell of the place you grew up. The forgetting is precise. It is not a malfunction. Something is doing it on purpose.*

11. Faction Sensitivity. *You can feel when a Faction Agent is within 200 meters of you. Useful. Also: you can feel when one is leaving. Knowing they were watching for the past hour is worse than not knowing.*

12. Anchor Tunneling. *When your Anchor Connection is in distress, you sense it. Not symbolically — physically. Headache, nausea, sometimes a pulled muscle in the side of the body that corresponds to where the person is geographically located. Most Echoes with Anchor Tunneling stop using it because the data is unbearable.*

13. The Slow Ear. *Speech directed at you takes a perceptible moment to resolve into language. People assume you're processing or thinking. You're not. You're waiting for their words to finish translating themselves into something you can hear.*

14. Mirror Lag. *Your reflection lags by a quarter-second. You can use the lag as a tell — your reflection's expression sometimes precedes the one you're about to make.*

15. The Cold Spot. *A specific volume of space, roughly two cubic feet, anywhere in your immediate environment, is six degrees colder than the rest of the room. You can feel where it is without looking. Other people feel it too but cannot locate it.*

16. Threshold Confusion. *You sometimes do not know whether a person is real or remembered. The confusion is brief — usually a second or two — but in that second you respond to a memory as if it were present, and the present moment moves on without you.*

17. Causal Sympathy. *When you injure yourself, the injury appears, faintly, on someone you are connected to. They do not feel it. They do not see it. You see it in them. The injury fades from them as yours heals.*

18. The Lost Word. *A word you used to use frequently is now permanently inaccessible. You can describe what it means, when you'd use it, where you learned it. You cannot say it. The word is in you somewhere. It does not come out.*

19. Frequency Bleed. *Music and ambient tone affect you more than they used to. A wrong note in the room three streets over is felt. You will learn to live with headphones.*

20. The Witness. *Once per day, someone who has been dead for at least ten years is briefly visible in your peripheral vision. You will not see them clearly. You will know who they are. They do not interact. They do not recur. They are, you think, checking on you.*

Optional — unlock after **3+ Memory losses** or **Paradox 8+**

OPTIONAL COMPLICATIONS

Prolonged displacement does things to a mind that don't have names in linear medicine. The conditions below are optional. They are not assigned automatically — a player may choose to roll on this table when a Memory becomes Lost, or when Paradox reaches **8+**, if they want a more specific shape to their Echo's deterioration. Roll **d6**, or choose the condition that fits your Echo's current state.

1 — COTARD'S DELUSION

You are certain, with absolute clarity, that you are already dead. Your body is a corpse being puppeted by temporal residue. This is not a crisis. It is simply a fact you've accepted. The rot is merely slow.

Mechanical effect: you are immune to fear-based intimidation and to the Scionfall Herald's opening offer (you're already dead — cessation holds no terror). However, you cannot gain Coherence from social connection, rest, or comfort. You can only gain Coherence by documenting evidence of your own death in your Chronicle — finding your own grave, reading your own obituary, meeting someone who attended your funeral.

To remove: survive a Crisis and roll **12+** on the resolution roll.

2 — FREGOLI DELUSION

Everyone you meet is the same person in a different disguise. The shopkeeper, the soldier, the woman on the train, the Faction Agent — all one entity, cycling through masks, watching you. You're not certain who it is. You're not certain it isn't you.

Mechanical effect: you cannot use the **SYNC** mode to build genuine trust with any new NPC — you can still manipulate, but not connect. Once per session, when an NPC acts against your interests, you may declare 'I knew it was you' — you gain **+1** on your next roll against them, but also gain **+1 Paradox** from the paranoid resonance.

To remove: form a genuine Recurring Thread with someone and protect them at personal cost.

3 — PALINOPSIA (TEMPORAL AFTERIMAGES)

You see the ghost of every action before it's completed — a visual echo of the recent past, overlapping the present. People are trailed by where they just were. You can see the moment before the punch lands.

Mechanical effect: once per session, before any roll, you may declare you are watching the afterimage of this moment. You may reroll one die and take the better result. However, the cognitive load is cumulative — every time you use this ability in a session after the first, lose **1 Coherence** from the strain of double-vision.

To remove: spend a full Downtime in complete darkness.

4 — THE GLASS VOICE

When you speak about a specific period of your past — usually the period surrounding your most significant Loss — your voice takes on a metallic, ringing quality. You can hear it. Others can hear it. The Church finds it beautiful.

Mechanical effect: **-1** to **SYNC** rolls when the conversation touches on the affected period. However, once per session, you may lean into the Glass Voice deliberately — describe speaking about that period with raw honesty. The authenticity creates an involuntary resonance. Gain **+2** to one **SYNC** roll immediately following. Church Templars who hear the Glass Voice are momentarily distracted (**-1** to their Drive Off roll against you this encounter).

To remove: Lock a new Memory that postdates the loss.

5 — MIRROR AGNOSIA

You no longer recognize the person in reflective surfaces as yourself. The recognition mechanism is simply gone — you see a stranger. Sometimes the stranger moves on a slight delay. You've stopped looking.

Mechanical effect: you cannot use reflective surfaces to gather information (normally a free **OBSERVE** action). At **Paradox 7+**, reflections show you a version of yourself from another timeline — this version has different Scars. You may ask one question of this version and receive a truthful answer, but gain +1 **Paradox** from the contact.

To remove: maintain **Anchor Strength 4+** for three consecutive sessions.

6 — CHRONAL APHASIA

Your internal sense of sequence has fractured. You know what happened but not when. Events from decades apart feel simultaneous. You lose track of which wounds are old and which are new.

Mechanical effect: during Downtime, before rolling to Reinforce your Anchor, roll **1d6**. On a **1-2**, you accidentally reinforce the wrong period — spend the Coherence but gain no benefit (you were thinking of a time that no longer holds meaning). On a **5-6**, you reinforce something deeper than intended — gain +2 **Coherence** instead of the normal benefit. The Oracle decides which period you accessed.

To remove: reduce Paradox to 0.

APPENDIX H

Recovered Testimony — The Saul Files



The pages that follow were not part of the original manuscript. They arrived after. A man who was not the man whose name he used spent fourteen months building a record of an event he was not present for, in a name he did not own, because the name fit better than anything he had been called before. He filed fifteen reports. He stopped at fifteen. We have arranged them here in chronological order, lightly annotated, because they belong with the rest of what this book is.

— EC

He kept looking. That is the thing the original could not do. The original froze. The journalist who took his name could not stop. He is in this book because he earned a place in it.

— Fragment

Read these last. They will not change the rules. They will change what you understand the rules to be the record of.

—AR

[FILES 001 THROUGH 015 INSERTED HERE FROM 'Final Scars and Fractures Guide' AND 'Diagetic_Pieces_.txt' — see project files for full text. Drop in numerical order with no other framing.]

TEMPORAL ECHOES / emiT DUOLOGY

CORE RESOLUTION

Roll: **2d6** + Mode Rating + Memory/Scar Bonus

10+ Complete Success —achieve goal, +1 Coherence (TE)

7– Success with Complication —succeed, cost or new problem 6–

Failure with Opportunity —choose: – Coherence OR +1 Paradox

MEMORY / SCAR BONUS

Active +2 Fading +1 Locked / Core +3 None +0

THE FOUR MODES

OBSERVE +1 Analyzing, perceiving, investigating, Navigation **SYNC**

+1 Empathy, social connection, blending in, Anchor reinforcement

ENDURE +1 Willpower, resilience, resisting corruption, recovering

Memories **DISRUPT** +0 Force, violence, breaking things, driving off

Agents

COHERENCE STATES — TEMPORAL ECHOES

Synchronized (+6 to +8) +1 to all rolls Flux (0 to +5) No modifier

Desynchronizing (– to –) – to all rolls Crisis (–) – to all rolls.

Immediate Crisis.

Max = Anchor Strength + 5. Banked Coherence: bank up to 3 to spend 1-for-1 against future losses. emiT Wrecks do not bank.

COHERENCE STATES — emiT

Synchronized (+4 to +8) +1 to all rolls Flux (0 to +3) No modifier

Crisis (– to –) – to all rolls. At –: Fracture Event. Max = Corruption

Vector + 3. No Coherence banking in emiT.

PARADOX BANDS

Paradox accumulates and the universe responds, but not in a linear trajectory. Paradox is best represented in four bands, with each one presenting a corresponding state of attention.

SHADOW (0–3). *You are background noise. Factions ignore you. Small reality glitches occur — déjà vu, objects slightly wrong, conversations you can't quite remember the start of. No mechanical penalties. Most Echoes spend most of their time here. The trick is staying.* — EC

FLUX (4–6). *The timeline notices. -1 to all Resolution rolls. Memory Fading accelerates. Faction Scouts may appear when you roll 6-. This is where the dreams start. Not nightmares — déjà vu so persistent you begin to suspect the day is repeating itself a little.* — EC

ANOMALY (7–9). *You are an active disturbance. -1 ongoing. NPCs from contradictory timelines may appear and contradict each other in front of you. Faction Agents track you actively. Here is where Echoes begin to make the wrong kinds of friends. The Church reaches out. Scionfall reaches out. Both of them seem reasonable when you're at 7.* — EC

BREACH (10+). *Reality is unraveling locally. -2 ongoing. Crisis triggers within **1d6*** sessions. Factions converge. I have been to Breach twice. I do not recommend it. The world stops feeling solid in a specific way: edges become suggestions. The thing I lost in Breach the second time, I have never gotten back.* — EC*

NAVIGATION — TEMPORAL ECHOES

Cost: 1 Coherence before rolling. Cannot attempt at 0 Coherence or Paradox 7+. Roll: **2d6** + **OBSERVE** + Memory Bonus. Specific date + location **Difficulty 12** Year + city **Difficulty 10** Decade + region **Difficulty 8** Century + continent **Difficulty 7**

12+ Perfect Resonance —arrive exactly, +1 Coherence, no Paradox

10–1 Successful —arrive at target, minor variance, +1 Paradox **7–** Close Arrival —right era OR location (not both), +1 Paradox **6–** Lost in Transit —use Anomaly Tables. – Coherence OR +2 Paradox

NAVIGATION — EMI'T

Cost: 1 Coherence before rolling. Cannot attempt at Paradox 7+. Roll: **2d6** + **OBSERVE** + Scar Bonus. Nearby / been there before **Difficulty 7** Distant / unfamiliar **Difficulty 10** Extreme / specific moment **Difficulty 12**

12+ Perfect Landing —arrive exactly when and where intended. +1 Coherence. No Paradox.

10–1 Successful Navigation —arrive at target. +1 Paradox. **7–** Close Enough —right era OR right location, not both. +1 Paradox. **6–** Crash Landing —roll Chronoscape Oracle. – Coherence OR +2 Paradox.

DOWNTIME STEPS (TE)

1. Chronicle the session → +1 Coherence 2. Reinforce Anchor (**2d6** + **SYNC** if Stressed — clears Anchor Stress) 3. Tend Assets (**2d6** + Mode per Stressed Asset) 4. Process Memory (Active → Fading → Lost → Scar, automatic) 5. Reduce Paradox (optional) 6. Plan Next Move (answer one question)

REPREIVAL STEPS (EMI'T)

1. Chronicle → +1 Coherence 2. Reinforce Anchor (**2d6** + **SYNC** if Stressed) 3. Tend Assets 4. Process Scars (Active → Fading → Lost → Mutation, automatic) 5. Reduce Paradox (optional) 6. Plan Next Move 7. Reset Violence Count to 0

FACTION ENCOUNTERS

Church Templar Take 1 Scar + lose 2 Coh → Reduce Paradox by 3 Authority Corrector Normalize 1 Active Memory (bonus → +0) → Paradox – Scionfall Herald Character retired. Game ends peacefully. Chronoclast Remixer +2 Paradox now → +3 to next DISRUPT or **OBSERVE** (Complication guaranteed)

Drive Off: **2d6** + DISRUPT **Difficulty 10**. **10+**: no Mark. **7–**: success with cost. **6–** fail, take consequence and Marked.

EMI'T MODE SHIFTS BY PARADOX

Shadow (0–) +2 / +1 / +0 / – Flux (4–) +1 / +0 / +1 / +1 Anomaly (7–) +0 / – / +2 / +2 Breach (10+) – / – / +3 / +3

ANCHOR STRESS (TE)

Anchor Stress (clear during Downtime Step 2): ○ ○ ○

Mark 1 when: Church captures you / fail Locked Memory roll in Desynchronization / Downtime in era contradicting Anchor Connection / Crisis outcome specifies it.

All 3 = Strained. Cannot invoke Connections for Coherence. **6–** on Reinforce Anchor = – Anchor Strength permanently.

DISPLACEMENT COSTS

Precision Navigation (voluntary) – Coherence (paid before rolling)
 Failed Navigation (6– – Coherence OR +2 Paradox Forced
 Displacement (Faction/Crisis/random) – Coherence Crisis
 Displacement (Shattering/Breach) – Coherence

TEMPORAL ECHOES — CHARACTER SHEET**THE PERSON YOU WERE**

Name: _____ Origin

Era: _____

Displacement _____ Event:

TEMPORAL ANCHOR

Anchor Strength: ○ 1 ○ 2 ○ 3 ○ 4 ○ 5 Maximum Coherence: _____
 (Anchor Strength + 5) Anchor Stress (clear during Downtime Step 2):
 ○ ○ ○ All 3 = STRAINED. Cannot invoke Connections for
 Coherence. 6–on Reinforce = – Anchor Strength.

ANCHOR CONNECTIONS

1: _____ 2:

_____ 3:

OPERATIONAL MODES

OBSERVE (+1) ○– ○+0 ○+1 ○+2 ○+3 **SYNC** (+1) ○– ○+0 ○+1 ○+2
 ○+3 **ENDURE** (+1) ○– ○+0 ○+1 ○+2 ○+3 **DISRUPT** (+0) ○– ○+0
 ○+1 ○+2 ○+3

WAVE COHERENCE (CIRCLE CURRENT)

[–] [–] [–] [–] [–] [–] [0] [+1] [+2] [+3] [+4] [+5] [+6] [+7] [+8]

Banked Coherence (max 3, TE only) (spend 1-for-1 to absorb
 Coherence loss): ○ ○ ○

PARADOX TRACK

[0] [1] [2] [3] \ [4] [5] [6] \ [7] [8] [9] \ [10+]

ACTIVE MEMORIES (+2)

1. Title: _____ Tags:

_____ /

2. Title: _____ Tags:

_____ /

3. Title: _____ Tags:

_____ /

4. Title: _____ Tags:

_____ /

5. Title: _____ Tags:

_____ /

FADING MEMORIES (+1)

1: _____ 2: _____
 _____ 3: _____

LOCKED MEMORY (+3, permanent)

Title: _____ Tags: _____
 _____ Why this one: _____

ASSETS

Asset 1: _____ Type: _____
 ○ Chrono-Tech ○ Echo Trait ○ Temporal Anchor Level: ○ 1 ○ 2 ○ 3
 Stress: ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ Asset 2: _____
 _____ Type: ○ Chrono-Tech ○ Echo Trait ○ Temporal Anchor Level: ○ 1 ○ 2 ○ 3 Stress: ○ ○ ○ ○ ○
 Asset 3: _____ Type: _____
 ○ Chrono-Tech ○ Echo Trait ○ Temporal Anchor Level: ○ 1 ○ 2 ○ 3
 Stress: ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

FACTION TRACKING

Marked: ○ Church ○ Authority ○ Scionfall ○ Chronoclasts

SCARS (FROM LOST MEMORIES)

1: _____ 2: _____
 _____ 3: _____
 _____ 4: _____

MUTATIONS (FROM BREACH/FACTION/CRISIS)

1: _____ 2: _____

DOWNTIME CHECKLIST

☐ Chronicle (+1 Coherence) ☐ Reinforce Anchor ☐ Tend Assets ☐
 Process Memory ☐ Reduce Paradox (optional) ☐ Plan Next Move

emiT — CHARACTER SHEET**ORIGIN SKETCH (WRITE IN PENCIL)**

Name _____ (subject _____ to _____ revision):
 _____ Origin Era:

 Displacement _____ Event:

CORRUPTION VECTOR

[5] → [4] → [3] → [2] → [1] → [0: **TERMINAL CONFIGURATION**]

Current _____ Vector: _____ Trajectory:

Decreases when: Embrace Corruption in Crisis / 3rd Mutation in one session / accept Faction transformation offer.

OPERATIONAL MODES (SHIFT BY PARADOX BAND)

Shadow (0-) +2 / +1 / +0 / - Flux (4-) +1 / +0 / +1 / +1 Anomaly
 (7-) +0 / - / +2 / +2 Breach (10+) - / - / +3 / +3

Current Band: _____
 Current Modes: _____ / _____ / _____ / _____

COHERENCE (CIRCLE CURRENT)

[-] [-] [-] [-] [-] [-] [0] [+1] [+2] [+3] [+4] [+5] [+6] [+7] [+8]

Max = Corruption Vector + 3. No Coherence banking in emiT.

PARADOX

[0] [1] [2] [3] \ [4] [5] [6] \ [7] [8] [9] \ [10+]

ACTIVE SCARS (+2, tools you reload)

1. Title: _____ Tags: _____
 _____ /
 _____ Invocation: _____

2. Title: _____ Tags: _____
 _____ /
 _____ Invocation: _____

3. Title: _____ Tags: _____
 _____ /
 _____ Invocation: _____

4. Title: _____ Tags: _____
 _____ /
 _____ Invocation: _____

5. Title: _____ Tags: _____
 _____ /
 _____ Invocation: _____

FADING SCARS (+1)

1: _____ 2: _____
 _____ 3: _____

CORE SCAR (+3, permanent)

Title: _____ Tags: _____
 _____ Why this one: _____

MUTATIONS (PERMANENT)

1: _____ 2: _____
 _____ 3: _____
 _____ 4: _____

VIOLENCE TAX TRACKER

Violence Count (reset at Reprival): ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ ○ Taxes:
 ○ Mutation ○ Scar Loss ○ Witnessed

ASSETS**ASSETS****Asset 1:** _____

- Type: ○ Chrono-Tech ○ Echo Trait ○ Scar-Derived
- Level: ○ 1 ○ 2 ○ 3
- State: ○ Clean ○ Compromised ○ Weaponized
- Stress: ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Asset 2: _____

- Type: ○ Chrono-Tech ○ Echo Trait ○ Scar-Derived
- Level: ○ 1 ○ 2 ○ 3
- State: ○ Clean ○ Compromised ○ Weaponized
- Stress: ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

Asset 3: _____

- Type: ○ Chrono-Tech ○ Echo Trait ○ Scar-Derived
- Level: ○ 1 ○ 2 ○ 3
- State: ○ Clean ○ Compromised ○ Weaponized
- Stress: ○ ○ ○ ○ ○

FACTION TRACKING

Marked: ○ Church ○ Authority ○ Scionfall ○ Chronoclasts

REPRIEVAL CHECKLIST

- ☐ Chronicle
- ☐ Reinforce Anchor
- ☐ Tend Assets
- ☐ Process Scars
- ☐ Reduce Paradox (optional)
- ☐ Plan Next Move
- ☐ Reset Violence Count

THE HOLDING ACTION (ONCE PER SESSION)

Used this session: ○

THE EXIT QUESTION (AT CORRUPTION VECTOR ○)

What was the last thing you cared about that wasn't useful? Answer:

_____ ○ Preserve It —
 one final scene, then Dissolve. ○ Delete It — become Terminal
 Configuration. Rename **SYNC** to INTERFACE.

The signal does not decay. It is the receiver that rots. To hear the sweet siren song of the Chronoverse is to invite the frequency to dismantle you. Identity is a standing wave. You are not a traveler. You are an interference pattern. Chen believes she can stabilize the note. Alan believes he can change the key. Both are wrong. There is only the static. And the static is hungry. The other three argue about how to survive the ocean. Chen builds a boat. Alan learns to breathe water. Zaaken dissolves into the current.

I am the fourth.

I am the one who asked what the ocean was for.

I found the shore. I found the Architect. I cannot tell you what I saw. I can only leave you

— 211 — this: The Veil is thin where the signal is loudest. Do not listen. Do not look. Do not stop moving. They are listening back.